NexKit
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THE PHONE-FIRST EDITION

05

# Canva to Cash

## How to Start a Simple Graphic Design Service Using Free Tools

Learn the design rules, build a ten-piece portfolio, and sell design to local businesses.

10 service packages

Design rules that work

Clients without an agency


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GLOBAL EDITION · FIRST EDITION · SEPTEMBER 2026

# Canva to Cash

How to Start a Simple Graphic Design Service Using Free Tools

LEGAL, DISCLAIMER AND HOW TO READ THIS

## Copyright & Disclaimer

Canva to Cash — First Edition · September 2026. Publisher: **NexKit your country Editorial Team**.

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### What this course is

A practical, your country-specific manual for starting a small graphic design service using free tools and, where necessary, only a phone. It teaches the design rules that separate amateur work from professional work, the client work small local businesses actually buy, a ten-piece portfolio you can build before you have a single client, pricing in dollars, ten service packages, the exact words to send a client, how to find buyers, how to get paid legally where you live, and a fourteen-day plan that ends with real outreach sent.

Every price, fee and platform fact that is not clearly labelled as a teaching example is traceable to a published source listed in Sources & Further Reading.

### What this course is not

It is not a promise of income. It is not a guarantee of clients, replies, orders or results. It is not financial, legal, tax or investment advice, and it is not a substitute for a qualified accountant or lawyer where you live.

It does not claim that any particular design tool, free plan, template, export option or payment route is available to you today. Design is one of the most crowded beginner services where you live, and this course says so plainly instead of pretending otherwise.

DISCLAIMER — INCOME, EXAMPLES AND YOUR RESPONSIBILITIES

This course is educational only. **There is no income guarantee of any kind.** Nothing in it should be read as a prediction of what you will earn, how many clients will answer you, or how quickly you will be paid.

Every business, client, message and scenario in this course is invented for teaching, and every one is labelled **Example scenario — fictional**. Every price in dollars is an **example price for teaching**, not a market rate, not a published rate card and not a quotation. There is no published local rate card for design work that this course could verify, so you must calibrate your own prices by asking local businesses what they currently pay.

You are responsible for complying with local law, your tax obligations, the terms of service of any platform you use, and the requirements of any bank, wallet or payment provider you receive money through. Rules, fees, limits and country availability change. Verify anything that matters to you before you rely on it.

FIGURES, DATES AND UNRESOLVED QUESTIONS

All figures cited in this course are current as of **September 2026** unless a specific date is printed next to the figure. Source URLs for those figures appear in **Sources & Further Reading** at the back of this course.

local payment rules, data prices and platform availability move quickly. Where this course could not verify a fact, it says so in the text and tells you to confirm it yourself. Those gaps were left as gaps on purpose.

### ON DESIGN TOOLS, FONTS AND PRINT SHOPS

This course teaches rules and a workflow that work in any template-based free design tool. Tool names appear as examples only. Free-plan limits, template libraries, font lists and export options change without notice, and they were not verified against the vendor pages for this edition. **Check the current free limits yourself before you build a workflow on any tool.**

Printing prices, paper stock, bleed requirements and turnaround times are set by individual print shops. This course does not print a single printing price, because there is no verified public source for one. Ask your own print shop.

**Last updated:** September 2026. Questions or corrections: use the contact address supplied with your purchase.

# What is inside this course

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**HOW TO WORK THROUGH THIS COURSE**

Skim the section dividers first so you can see the whole route. Then work one section at a time and finish the **DO** tasks before moving to the next. The scripts, templates and checklists are meant to be copied, filled in and sent — not admired.

FRONT MATTER

# Before You Start

This course teaches one thing: how to turn a free design tool and about two hours a day into a small paid service that small local businesses actually buy.

## What this course can help you do

- Apply the design rules that make a beginner's flyer look like it came from an office instead of a phone.
- Build a ten-piece portfolio before you have a single paying client, honestly labelled so nobody thinks you are lying.
- Price work in dollars using your own hours plus the size and value of the client, with ten ready service packages.
- Send ten different outreach messages, word for word, to real small local businesses.
- Handle revisions, late payments, disappearing clients and the relative who designs for free.
- Get paid legally as an individual where you live, and know the limits of what you can and cannot do without a licence.
- Finish a fourteen-day plan with a portfolio, a price list and outreach sent.

## What this course cannot do

It cannot get you clients. It cannot promise an income, a reply rate or a timeline. It cannot make a beginner's work equal to a designer with five years of practice, and it cannot tell you what design work costs in your city, because **there is no published local rate card for design work that this course could verify**. What it can do is remove the excuses: you will know what to make, what to charge as a starting example, what to say, and how to deliver.

## What you need

| ITEM | WHY YOU NEED IT | NOTES |
|---|---|---|
| An Android phone | Design app, camera, messaging, delivery | Almost everything in this course is possible on a phone |
| A free design tool with templates | Layout, text, resize, export | Free plans change. Check the current free limits before you build a workflow on one |
| A free AI chat tool, where available | Drafting client messages, rewriting captions, translating English into simple the local language you then correct yourself | Optional. Never paste a client's private content into a tool you do not trust |

| ITEM | WHY YOU NEED IT | NOTES |
|---|---|---|
| Google Drive | One shared folder for delivery, one folder link as your portfolio | Free storage is limited. Compress exports |

| ITEM | WHY YOU NEED IT | NOTES |
|---|---|---|
| Your phone camera | Product photographs, before/after shots, mock-ups of printed work | Daylight near a window beats any filter |

| ITEM | WHY YOU NEED IT | NOTES |
|---|---|---|
| A data bundle | Uploads, messages, template downloads | A 2 GB monthly bundle is around $0.60 on an indicative published guide. Work on Wi-Fi where you can |

Bundle prices are indicative and change often. Check your own operator's current offer. Source: Awajis Ethio Telecom data-plan guide, listed in Sources & Further Reading.

## Time you actually need

Plan for **about two hours a day for fourteen days**. That is the honest figure, not a motivational one. If you have less, use the five-hour fast path later in this front matter. If you have more, you will finish faster and start outreach sooner, which matters more than a perfect portfolio.

## Phone or laptop — be exact about this

A phone is enough for most of this work, but not all of it. Pretending otherwise wastes your money and your client's time.

**Genuinely fine on a phone**

- Single-sided flyers, social posts, invitations, business cards
- Resizing one design into square, portrait and landscape versions
- Photographing and cleaning product images
- Client messages, quotes, revisions, delivery through a shared folder
- Building a ten-piece sample portfolio

**Really needs a laptop**

- Multi-page menus, brochures and price lists with 40 or more text items, where precise alignment matters
- Print-ready PDFs with exact trim size, bleed and crop marks
- Font installation when the printer demands a specific font
- Uploading large files on a weak connection without the app timing out
- Assembling a multi-page PDF portfolio in one document

**If you have no laptop:** keep menus and brochures to one page and under twenty items, ask the print shop to typeset the long price list from your clean text file, or use a friend's laptop, a university computer lab, or an internet cafe for one hour to export the final print PDF. That one hour is the cheapest part of the whole job.

Free plans change. Verify the current free limits before you build a workflow on a tool — including how many exports you get, whether a watermark appears, and which file types you can download.

**THE MOST IMPORTANT RULE**

**Never send a design you would not put your own name on.**

Not a rushed flyer at midnight because the client is pushing. Not a menu with one item misspelled because you did not read it out loud. Not a post with a phone number that is one digit wrong. Your first ten clients come from other people seeing your work, and one careless file cancels ten good impressions.

If you would not hang it in your own family's shop, do not send it. Ask for two more hours instead of sending something you already know is weak. Clients respect a designer who says "I need until tomorrow morning to do this properly" far more than one who sends work that has to be redone.

FRONT MATTER

# Who This Is For, and Who It Is Not For

**This is for you if**

- You are 18 to 30, a student, a recent graduate, or working a job that does not pay enough, and you want a second income you build yourself.
- You have already opened a free design tool and enjoyed it, even if what you made was not good.
- You can give two hours a day for two weeks before expecting anything back.
- You can look at your own work and admit when it is weak.
- You are willing to send messages to strangers and take silence as normal.
- You live in your city, or in a regional city, a regional city, a regional city, a regional city, a regional city, a regional city, a regional city, a smaller town, a smaller town or anywhere else with businesses that advertise.

**This is not for you if**

- You want to earn this week without doing the fourteen days. Design work is sold on the strength of what a buyer can see, and you will have nothing to show.
- You want a design tool to do the work while you press a button. Templates help you start; they do not choose your client's message, price or photograph.
- You are looking for passive income. This is active service work. You are paid per piece or per month, and the work stops when you stop.
- You want to sell internationally from day one on a payment rail this course cannot verify. Read Section 09 before you plan around that.
- You are unwilling to correct the local language spelling and grammar. A misspelled the local language word in a shop's poster is worse than an ugly poster.

**COURSE OBJECTIVES**

By the end of this course you should be able to: name the ten design products small local businesses buy and what each one is worth as a starting example; explain contrast, alignment, repetition, proximity, white space and hierarchy well enough to critique your own work; produce print-ready and screen-ready files; present a labelled ten-piece portfolio; quote from a published price list of your own; run a client conversation from first message to final folder; and know exactly which payment routes are legal and verified for someone where you live.

FRONT MATTER

# How to Use This Course

## Phone-first, not phone-only

Read this on the device you will work on. Every workflow is written for a phone first, with the laptop step named where it is genuinely better. When you see LAPTOP next to a step, that step is worth borrowing a laptop for. When you see EITHER, a phone is fine.

## Low-data mode

- Download templates and fonts while you are on Wi-Fi or a bundle you are not saving.
- Do your reading and planning offline. This course is text-first on purpose, so it opens on a weak connection.
- Export previews at the smallest size your tool allows, then export the final file once.
- Compress before you send. A shop owner on a small bundle will not open a 40 MB file, and they will not tell you why.
- Keep a plain text file of your price list and messages so you can copy and paste without loading anything heavy.

## The pattern in every lesson

Lessons use four steps: **Explain** what the idea is, **Show** it in an local example, **Do** the exact action, and **Check** how you know it is done properly. The *Do* line is the one that matters. Reading design advice changes nothing; making ten files changes everything.

> **ONE HABIT TO BUILD FROM DAY ONE**
>
> Keep every file you make. Even the ones you hate. In three months a client will ask for "the same style as that café thing" and you will need it. One folder per client, one folder for your own practice work, and never overwrite a final file with a new version.

FRONT MATTER

# If You Only Have Five Hours

This is the compressed path. It will not produce a professional portfolio, but it will put you in front of real buyers with something in your hand.

1. **Hour 1 — Learn six rules, not sixty**
   Read Section 02 and write down only these: contrast, alignment, repetition, proximity, white space, and two colours plus one neutral. Apply them to one square social post. Do not read further until that post is finished.

2. **Hour 2 — Make three samples from Section 04**
   A café flyer, a shop social post, and one event invitation. Label every one **Sample — created by [your name] for demonstration**. Three is enough to start a conversation.

1. **Hour 3 — Set three prices**

   Use the packages in Section 05 and pick three: a Starter five-post pack, a flyer, and a menu. Write your example prices in a notes file. You will adjust them after your first three conversations.

1. **Hour 4 — Build a prospect list of twenty**

   Open Google Maps. Pick your own neighbourhood plus one business district. List twenty businesses with a visible gap: no posts for months, photographed menus, no prices, no hours. Save them in a sheet with the gap written next to each name.

2. **Hour 5 — Send ten messages**

   Use the Instagram and Telegram scripts in Section 08. Ten messages, sent, not drafted. Expect silence from most of them. That is the normal starting condition, not a verdict on you.

**WHAT THE FIVE-HOUR PATH SKIPS**

It skips the ten-piece portfolio, print-ready files, the before/after redesign, the retainer conversation and the payment detail. Come back for those. Clients who pay well ask about them.

FRONT MATTER

# Honest Expectations About Money

Read this page twice. It is the page that decides whether you keep going after week two.

Design is the most competitive beginner service where you live. The barriers are low, the tools are free, and thousands of people can make a flyer. Low barriers mean low prices at the bottom of the market, and the bottom of the market is where beginners start. **Simple work is cheap.** A single social post is not a business.

The way out is not to work harder for the same price. It is to sell **packages** instead of single files, and to convert one-off buyers into **monthly retainers** so you are not starting from zero every month. Ten packages are laid out in Section 05. A retainer of twenty graphics and two video covers per month, priced as an example, is worth more than ten separate flyer jobs and takes less explaining.

**TARGET EXAMPLE — NOT A PREDICTION AND NOT A GUARANTEE**

```
4 retainer clients × $8,000 = $32,000 / month
or 16 one-off jobs × $12 = $32,000 / month
```

The same number, two very different lives. The retainer is fewer clients, fewer negotiations and predictable work. This is arithmetic, not a forecast. It assumes clients exist, agree, and pay.

To keep that number in perspective: the federal civil service entry step for a degree holder was raised to **$70 a month** in September 2025, and a planning proxy for young urban white-collar work in Addis is roughly **$35 to 15,000 a month**, labelled an estimate. Most small small local businesses are also not durable advertisers: more than 80% of federal business licences issued went dormant during 2025. Expect clients to come and go.

**THERE IS NO PUBLISHED RATE CARD. CALIBRATE BY ASKING.**

This course will not print a "market rate" for a flyer, because no verifiable published local rate card exists. Every price here is an **example to adjust**. The fastest way to find your real range is to ask local businesses what they currently pay: "If you were to pay someone for a poster like this, what would you expect to pay?" Ask five businesses and print shops. You will get a range, and that range is your market.

**WHAT SLOW MONTHS LOOK LIKE**

Some months you will send forty messages and get two replies. Some months you will be too busy to breathe. Neither month tells you anything permanent. Keep a list of people who said "not now" and contact them again in two months. Most beginner designers quit in the quiet month, right before the list they built starts working.

FRONT MATTER

# Your Starting Position

Fill this in before Section 01. In fourteen days you will compare it with where you ended up.

City or neighbourhood I will sell in .....

Device I will design on .....

Hours I can give per day .....

Design tool I will use .....

Three business types I know well .....

Wallet or bank account I can receive into .....

What I am most afraid of .....

Use these three lines as they are. Do not translate word for word from English in the middle of a client conversation; short correct the local language is more persuasive than long uncertain the local language.

01

SECTION ONE

# The Ten Things local Clients Actually Buy

Ten design products that small local businesses and families pay for, who buys each one, when they buy, an example beginner price in dollars, delivery time and the main quality risk.


01 The ten products, with buyers, timing and example prices

02 When small local businesses spend: the occasion calendar

03 Handling sensitive occasions with care

04 Which three products you should start with

Nobody buys "graphic design". They buy a poster for a shop opening, a menu with prices on it, ten posts for the fasting season, a card for a wedding. This section gives you the ten products that local buyers actually pay for, and the words to describe them.

Read the table. Then pick three products and refuse to sell anything else for your first month. A beginner who does three things well earns more than one who offers everything badly.

## 1.1 The ten products

**EXPLAIN** A design product is a named, repeatable piece of work with a fixed output: one flyer, one menu, ten posts. When the work has a name, the client can say yes without a long conversation, and you can deliver it without guessing.

**SHOW** **Example scenario — fictional.** the commercial district Beans Café (a fictional café in the commercial district, your city) asks for "something for our Instagram". No name, no shape, no price. Ten messages later you still do not know what they want. The same café asked "Do you want the Starter pack, five posts a month at $16, or the Standard, fifteen posts at $35?" answers in one message.

**DO** Copy the table below into your notes. Delete every row you are not willing to deliver in your first month. Keep three.

**CHECK** You can say your three products, their example price and their delivery time out loud in under thirty seconds, in English or the local language.

| PRODUCT | WHO BUYS IT | WHEN THEY BUY | EXAMPLE PRICE | DELIVERY | MAIN QUALITY RISK |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Flyer** (A5, one side) | Cafés, salons, gyms, clinics, new shops | Opening, promotion, holiday offer | 800 – $9 | 1–2 days | Too much text; unreadable phone number |
| **Restaurant menu** | Restaurants, juice houses, hotels, cafeterias | New opening, price change, season change, fasting menu | 2,500 – $35 | 3–5 days | Prices wrong or misaligned; items grouped badly |
| **Social post pack** (10 posts) | Clothing shops, electronics shops, beauty brands, restaurants | Monthly content, new stock, sales | 2,000 – $120 | 3–5 days | Ten posts that look identical; spelling in captions |
| **Event invitation** | Families, churches, event planners, graduations | Weddings, graduations, conferences, memorials | 700 – $12 | 1–2 days | Wrong names, dates or times; crowded layout |
| **Business card** | Consultants, shops, tradespeople, real estate agents | New business, rebrand, first print run | 1,000 – $16 | 1–2 days | Text inside the trim area; unreadable at real size |

| PRODUCT | WHO BUYS IT | WHEN THEY BUY | EXAMPLE PRICE | DELIVERY | MAIN QUALITY RISK |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Poster or banner artwork** | Gyms, churches, concerts, campaigns, shops | Events, holidays, promotions, campaigns | 1,500 – $25 | 2–3 days | Designing at the wrong size for the printer |
| **Brochure or one-pager** | Tour operators, clinics, schools, NGOs, consultancies | Season launch, funding round, enrolment | 2,000 – $120 | 3–6 days | Poor photo quality; inconsistent spacing |

| PRODUCT | WHO BUYS IT | WHEN THEY BUY | EXAMPLE PRICE | DELIVERY | MAIN QUALITY RISK |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Presentation cover and slides** | Startups, students, consultancies, training centres | Pitch, workshop, graduation, tender | 1,500 – $25 | 2–4 days | Logos stretched; text unreadable on a projector |

| PRODUCT | WHO BUYS IT | WHEN THEY BUY | EXAMPLE PRICE | DELIVERY | MAIN QUALITY RISK |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Product graphics** (10 images) | Clothing, electronics, cosmetics, online sellers | New stock, marketplace listings, sales | 1,500 – $25 | 2–4 days | Cut-out edges; inconsistent background colour |
| **Social media package** (monthly) | Any business already posting weekly | Monthly, once they see it works | 6,000 – $15,000 / month | Ongoing | Missing deadlines; running out of ideas by week three |

All prices are **example prices for teaching, not market rates and not quotations**. There is no published local rate card for design that this course could verify. Adjust after asking local businesses what they currently pay. All buyer examples are fictional.

## 1.2 When small local businesses spend

Design demand follows money and occasions. Knowing the season means you stop guessing who to message this week.

| PERIOD | WHAT BUYERS WANT | WHO TO APPROACH |
|---|---|---|
| local New Year and a national holiday season (September) | Greeting posts, sale flyers, shop refresh, new price lists | Shops, cafés, salons, clothing stores |
| Christmas and a religious festival season (January) | Family offers, gift graphics, festive menus, event posters | Restaurants, gift shops, hotels, churches |
| a religious holiday and Eid periods (dates move each year) | Fasting menus, holiday hours, greeting graphics | Restaurants, butchers, sweets shops, groceries |
| Graduation and wedding season (largely June to September, plus January) | Invitations, thank-you cards, photograph overlays, banners | Families, photographers, event planners, halls |
| Rainy season slow months | Cheaper, smaller work: single posts, small flyers | Any business testing you with one paid piece |
| New shop openings (all year) | Full opening kit: sign artwork, flyer, posts, price list | New businesses found on Google Maps and a local classifieds site |
| Exam and enrolment season | Tutoring adverts, school brochures, registration posters | Tutoring centres, private colleges, training institutes |

Holiday dates follow the local calendar and move against the Gregorian calendar. Confirm the exact dates for the year you are working in before you promise a deadline.

## 1.3 Sensitive occasions: handle with care

> **NEVER TREAT MOURNING AS A MARKETING OPPORTUNITY**

Memorial programmes, funeral notices and bereavement cards are real design work where you live, and families pay for them. They are also the easiest way to ruin your reputation. Rules: **never send an unsolicited sample for a death or a memorial.** Never use cheerful colours, celebratory borders or promotional wording. Ask the family what they want, use the photograph they give you without filter or creative editing, spell every name and date twice, and deliver early rather than beautifully. Do not post the work in your portfolio without explicit permission.

The same restraint applies to religious occasions and fasting periods. Do not put a coffee cup, a beer bottle or a fashion model on a fasting-season menu. When you are not sure, ask the client one direct question instead of guessing.

## 1.4 Choose three products and stop

**01 Your fastest product**

Usually a flyer or a single social post. Cheap, quick, low risk. It gets you a paid yes and a testimonial.

**02 Your best-value product**

A post pack or a menu. Higher price, still repeatable, and it teaches you to work with a real content list.

**03 Your future retainer**

A monthly package. One client here is worth several one-off jobs and removes the monthly search for work.

Product 1 — fastest .....

Product 2 — best value .....

Product 3 — future retainer .....

Business types I will approach first .....

02

SECTION TWO

# Design Fundamentals That Separate Amateur From Professional

The six layout rules that do most of the work, how to limit colour and type, text sizes for print and screen, the squint test, and the local specifics of the local language script, local colour and printing in Addis.


01 Contrast, alignment, repetition, proximity, white space, hierarchy

02 Colour and type limits: two or three colours, one family, two or three weights

03 Text size for print and for screen, and the squint test

04 Designing the local language and Ge'ez script beside Latin text

05 Local colour and motif without cliché

06 How printing actually works in Addis: ask first, proof always

Good design is not decoration. It is the fastest way to make a message readable, believable and worth acting on. Six rules do most of that work, and none of them need talent.

This section is the technical heart of the course. Everything you sell later is judged against it.

## 2.1 The six rules

**EXPLAIN** **Contrast** makes one thing obviously more important than everything else. **Alignment** means every element lines up with something else. **Repetition** means the same colours, fonts and shapes come back. **Proximity** means related things sit together and unrelated things are separated. **White space** is the empty area that lets the eye rest. **Hierarchy** is the order in which a reader sees things: headline, then offer, then detail, then contact.

**SHOW** **Example scenario — fictional.** Lakeview Style House (fictional clothing shop) sends you a flyer with nine fonts, a rainbow of colours and text touching every edge. You rebuild it with two fonts, two colours plus white, one big headline, three short lines, and a clearly boxed phone number. Same information. It now reads in three seconds instead of thirty.

**DO** Open your last design. Count the fonts, the colours, and the number of elements touching the page edge. Rewrite it with at most two fonts, three colours including black or white, and clear margins on all four sides.

**CHECK** Cover the design with your hand and slide it away slowly. Your eye should land on the headline first, the offer second, the contact third. If it lands somewhere random, the hierarchy is broken.

### Contrast — use size, weight and space, not more colours

The easiest professional habit is a strong jump in size: a headline roughly three times the size of body text. Small, polite differences look like mistakes. If two things are not the same, make them clearly different.

### Alignment — pick one invisible line and obey it

Left-align almost everything. Left-aligned text is easier to read and easier to check. Centre-aligned text is fine for invitations and posters, but only when every line is genuinely centred, not nearly centred. If an element is not aligned to anything, move it or delete it.

### Repetition — the reason brand kits exist

Use the same two colours, the same two fonts and the same corner style across every piece for one client. Repetition is what makes a small shop look established. It is also faster for you: once the kit exists, a new post takes fifteen minutes instead of an hour.

### Proximity — group what belongs together

Put the price next to the item, the phone number next to the shop name, and space between groups. A menu where every item sits the same distance apart reads as a wall of text, and a wall of text loses sales.

### White space — the cheapest upgrade you can make

Beginners fill every centimetre because empty space feels like wasted money. It is the opposite. Margins and gaps make a design look expensive, and they make text readable on a phone screen in sunlight. If a layout feels crowded, remove an element before you shrink the text.

### Hierarchy — decide what the reader sees first

1. **One headline**

   What is this? "New menu at the commercial district Beans" or "50% off this week". One line, big.

1. **One supporting line**

   Why should I care? "Fresh juice, open from 7am".

1. **One action**

   What do I do? Address, phone, or a QR code if the client uses one.

2. **Everything else, smaller**

   Opening hours, terms, social handle. Present but quiet.

## 2.2 Colour and type limits

### Two or three colours, then stop

Choose one dark base colour, one accent, and white or off-white. If the client has a logo colour, that is your accent. Additional colours should come from photographs, not from the palette.

Check contrast: dark text on light background, or light text on a genuinely dark background. Grey text on a busy photo is invisible on a phone.

### One typeface family, two or three weights

Regular for body, semibold or bold for headings. If you must use two families, pair a Latin family with the local language family that matches its weight, and keep the pairing for the whole project.

Never stretch, squeeze or hand-scale text to make it fit. Change the size, shorten the words, or change the layout.

**THE 2–3 RULE IN PRACTICE**

Two fonts. Three colours. Three text sizes. One alignment. One margin. That is a whole design system, and it will outlast a folder of effects. Every effect you add after that should be justified by making something easier to read.

## 2.3 Text size for print and for screen

| USE | WORKING RULE OF THUMB | WHY |
|---|---|---|
| Print body text (flyer, menu, brochure) | Around 9–11 pt; never below about 7 pt for anything a customer must read | Small print looks cheap and gets ignored; older customers cannot read it at all |
| Print headings | Two to three times the body size | Creates obvious hierarchy at a glance |
| Poster or banner seen from a distance | One message, readable from several metres; test from across a room | A poster is read in motion, not studied |
| Square social post | Designed at 1080 × 1080 pixels; headline large enough to read on a small screen without zooming | Most people see it on a phone, often in bright light |
| Story or vertical post | Portrait format, with text kept away from the very top and bottom where platform controls sit | Your text gets hidden behind buttons and captions |
| Presentation slide | One idea per slide; assume the back row cannot read anything smaller than a headline | Slides support a speaker, they do not replace one |

These are working rules of thumb, not platform specifications. Check the current recommended sizes inside your design tool's resize menu before you deliver a file.

### The squint test

Shrink the design to thumbnail size, or squint until the text blurs. What remains visible is your hierarchy. If the blurred shape is one grey mass with no clear first, second and third, start again with size and space rather than with decoration. Then do the opposite test: view it at 100% on the smallest phone you can find. If the phone number is hard to read, it is too small.

## 2.4 the local language and Ge'ez script beside Latin text

**THE FOUR MISTAKES THAT MAKE THE LOCAL LANGUAGE LOOK AMATEUR**

1. **Stretching the fidel.** Pulling the local language text wider or taller to fill a space breaks the letterforms. Scale proportionally, or change the size and let the layout breathe.
2. **Too little line height.** Ge'ez script has taller and deeper shapes than Latin. Give the local language lines noticeably more space than you would give English, roughly 1.6 to 1.8 times the text size, and never let two the local language lines touch.
3. **A Latin-only font with the local language pasted over it.** If the local language appears in a different, heavier or lighter style than the English beside it, the whole piece looks assembled rather than designed. Use a proper a font that supports that script, and match its weight to the Latin.
4. **Letter-spacing and capitals.** Adding wide letter spacing or styling the local language as "all caps" destroys readability. Ge'ez has no capital letters; use size and weight for emphasis instead.

**EXPLAIN** Bilingual design is not translation. It is two scripts sharing one grid. Decide which language leads, give it the bigger size, and let the other sit directly beneath or beside it at a size that is still comfortably readable.

**SHOW** **Example scenario — fictional.** A fictional tutoring centre in the central district wants one poster in the local language and English. the local language leads at the top, larger. English sits below at about 80% of that size. Both left-aligned to the same margin, same font weights, generous line spacing. Nothing is stretched to match the other script's length.

**DO** Take one existing design. Set the local language line height to about 1.7 and check every the local language word has its full shape with no clipping at the top of tall letters or below the baseline.

**CHECK** Read the local language out loud, slowly. Any word you cannot read at normal distance is either too small, too tight, or in the wrong font. Also ask one the local language-first reader to check the spelling. If they hesitate, fix it.

**FONT AVAILABILITY AND LICENSING**

Free tools ship with a limited font list, and some templates use fonts you cannot legally use for commercial print. Stick to fonts the tool offers for commercial use, and confirm the tool's current licence terms yourself. If a print shop asks for a specific font you do not have, send a PDF and let them handle font substitution, or ask them to supply the font file.

## 2.5 Local colour and motif without cliché

local design has a real visual language: tibeb borders, mesob weaving patterns, cross motifs, the shapes in traditional cloth.

Used with restraint, they make a piece feel local and specific. Used as wallpaper, they make it look like a cheap souvenir.

**Reads as considered**

- One deep base colour with one warm accent, and one motif used as a thin border or a single corner element
- Photographs of the actual shop, the actual food, the actual staff
- the local language typography treated as the main design element, not a decoration underneath English
- Restrained colour on religious or mourning material

**Reads as cheap**

- Flag colours on everything: green, yellow and red used as a full palette for a juice bar, a phone shop and a funeral notice alike
- Motifs stretched, repeated to the edges or rotated for no reason
- Stock photos of foreign cafés and foreign models for an local business
- Sacred symbols used to sell a product or decorate a promotion

**WHY FLAG COLOURS EVERYWHERE READS AS CHEAP**

When every flyer in the neighbourhood uses the same three national colours, the colours stop carrying meaning and start carrying noise. They also fight any real brand colour the client already has. Ask instead: what colour is the shop's sign, its chairs, its packaging? Build the palette from something the customer already sees. National colours on a national occasion, sparingly, is a choice. National colours on a laundry advert is a habit.

## 2.6 How printing actually works in Addis

You cannot control a printer. You can control whether you asked the right questions before you designed. Design first, ask later, and you will pay twice.

**EXPLAIN** A print shop needs four things from you: the exact finished size, extra space around the edge for trimming (bleed), the colour requirements it works with, and the file type it accepts. Get those four answers before you open the design tool.

**SHOW** **Example scenario — fictional.** You design a beautiful A5 flyer at exactly A5 with text 2 mm from the edge. The fictional print shop in the market district trims 3 mm off each side. Your phone number is cut in half. The shop reprints, and the cost comes out of your fee. One question, asked before you started, would have prevented it.

**DO** Before your next print job, walk into the print shop with the client's rough idea and ask the six questions in the copy box below. Write the answers down and keep them. Use the same shop until you have a reason not to.

**CHECK** You have, in writing: finished size, bleed requirement, file type, colour requirement, price per unit at the client's quantity, and turnaround time. If any answer is missing, you are not ready to design.

### COPY-READY: SIX QUESTIONS FOR YOUR PRINT SHOP

Selam. I design flyers and posters and I want to send you files you can print without problems.

1. What finished size do you print this as, in centimetres?
2. Do you need **[bleed]** around the edge, and how many millimetres?
3. Which file type do you prefer: **[PDF]**, JPG or PNG?
4. How should I set the colours so they print correctly on your machine?
5. For **[quantity]** copies on **[paper type]**, what is the price per copy and the total?
6. If I bring the file today, when can I collect it?

Thank you. I will bring the file and the customer's name and phone number.

### NEVER PROMISE COLOUR ACCURACY YOU CANNOT CONTROL

Colour shifts between screen and paper. A deep blue on your phone may print slightly duller. Tell the client honestly: "The screen colour and the printed colour can differ a little; I will bring a proof so you can approve it before the full run." Then bring the proof. **Always ask for a proof** on anything printed in quantity, and get the client's approval on the proof in writing, even if it is only a message saying "approved".

03

SECTION THREE

# The Design Workflow in a Free Tool, From Phone and From Laptop

A repeatable workflow: folders and a brand kit, using templates without looking templated, resizing for each platform, exporting the right file type, compressing for small data bundles, naming files, and delivering through one shared folder.


01 Folders, naming and the client brand kit

02 Starting from a template without it looking like a template

03 Resizing one design for several platforms

04 Exporting the right file type: PNG, JPG, PDF

05 Compressing files for small data bundles

06 Delivering through one shared folder, not twenty attachments

07 Phone versus laptop for every step in the workflow

A client does not pay for your creativity. They pay for a file that arrives on time, opens on their phone, and prints correctly. That is a workflow problem, and this section solves it once so you never rebuild it per job.

## 3.1 Folders, naming and the brand kit

1. **Make one master folder**

   Called `DESIGN WORK`. Inside it, one folder per client, named the same way every time: `2026-09 the commercial district Beans Cafe`. Year, month, client. Nothing else goes in that folder except that client's work.

2. **Inside each client folder, four subfolders**

   `01-content` for their text, photos and logo. `02-working` for drafts. `03-final` for approved files. `04-delivered` for exactly what you sent them.

3. **Build a one-page brand kit**

   A single image containing the client's logo, their two colours with the colour codes copied from the tool, their two fonts, and their phone number and handle. Every new design starts by looking at this page.

4. **Name files so you can find them in two years**

   Format: `client_product_version_date`. Example: `bolebeans_flyer_v3_2026-09-14.png`. Never "final", "final2" or "new new".

> **VERSION NUMBERS ARE A PROFESSIONALISM SIGNAL**
>
> When a client asks "which one is the latest?", answering with a file named `v3` takes one second. Answering "let me check" takes ten minutes and makes you look disorganised. Use `v1` for the first draft you send, `v2` after the first revision, and mark the approved file `FINAL` only after the client says yes in writing.

## 3.2 Starting from a template without it looking like a template

Templates are not cheating. They are a starting grid. The problem is that a thousand other designers started from the same one, and buyers recognise it.

| DO THIS | NOT THIS |
|---|---|
| Replace every placeholder image with the client's real photo | Leaving the smiling stock model in a shop that has never had a customer like that |
| Change the colour palette to the client's own colours | Keeping the template's default teal because it looks nice |
| Rewrite the headline for the actual offer | "Your headline here" or generic business English |
| Delete at least two elements you did not need | Filling every placeholder because the template had them |
| Rebuild the alignment to one clear margin | Trusting the template's decorative offsets |
| Check the fonts are commercially usable | Shipping a template font you have no licence for |

**A THREE-MINUTE TEST**

Search the design tool's template gallery for the template you used. If the first page of results shows four designs that look almost identical to yours, a client will eventually see one of them. Change the layout, not the decoration: move the headline, change the grid, replace the image treatment.

## 3.3 Resizing for several platforms

**EXPLAIN** Resizing is not one button. When you change the shape of a design, the composition must be re-decided: what stays big, what moves, what gets cut. Most tools have a resize feature that copies the design into new dimensions. Treat that copy as a new draft, not a finished file.

**SHOW** **Example scenario — fictional.** A square post for a fictional gym has the headline on two lines. Resized to a vertical story, the second line collides with the logo. The fix is not to shrink the text: it is to move the logo to the bottom and give the headline three lines with more leading.

**DO** Take one finished square design and produce two more versions: a vertical story and a wide banner. Adjust the layout in each by hand. Save them as separate files, not one file with three pages, unless the client asked for a single multi-page PDF.

**CHECK** Open all three on a phone at full size. Nothing is cut off, nothing overlaps, and the headline is still the first thing you read in each version.

## 3.4 Exporting the right file type

| WHAT IT IS FOR | FORMAT | WHY |
|---|---|---|
| Social media posts and stories | PNG | Sharp text and flat colours; no blurry compression artefacts around letters |
| Photographs and photo-heavy posts | JPG | Much smaller file for the same visible quality; ideal for small data bundles |
| Anything going to a printer | PDF | Keeps layout and text sharp at any size, and is what print shops expect |
| Client sending you a logo or photo | Ask for PNG or original file, never a screenshot | A screenshot loses quality and cannot be enlarged |
| Quick preview for approval | JPG, small size | Fast to open on a weak connection, which is how approvals actually happen |

**THE SCREENSHOT TRAP**

Never deliver a screenshot of your design. A screenshot loses sharpness, adds the phone's interface, and cannot be resized. Always use the tool's export or download button, even when the file is larger than a screenshot.

## 3.5 Compressing for a small data bundle

A shop owner with a 2 GB monthly bundle will not download a 40 MB file. They will say "it is not opening" and go quiet. Your delivery quality is judged on whether the file opens.

1. **Export one preview at low quality**
   A JPG around 500 KB is enough for approval on a phone. Send this first, always.
2. **Send the full-quality file only when asked**
   Or send it in the shared folder, not as a chat attachment. Let the client choose when to download it.
3. **Compress photographs before uploading**
   Most free tools let you reduce image quality on export. For social media, a JPG at moderate quality is visually identical to a PNG of four times the size.
4. **Keep print files out of the chat**
   A print PDF is deliberately large. Put it in the folder, tell the client the file name, and give them a small JPG preview in the message.

> **LOW-BANDWIDTH ALTERNATIVE FOR EVERY DELIVERY**
>
> Whenever you deliver, give the client two options in the same message: a small preview image that opens instantly, and one folder link for the full set. That way a client on a weak connection can still approve, and a client on Wi-Fi can still get the print file. Never make a download the only way to see your work.

## 3.6 One shared folder instead of twenty attachments

**EXPLAIN** Attachments scatter work across a chat. Three weeks later nobody knows which file is final. One shared folder with a fixed structure means both of you always know where the latest file lives.

**SHOW** **Example scenario — fictional.** Instead of sending eleven Telegram images to a fictional restaurant, you send one link to a folder called `a national holiday Kitchen – Menu – September 2026` with subfolders `Previews` and `Print files`. The owner opens it on a phone, sees two folders, and finds the file without asking you a single question.

**DO** Create the folder structure now, with your client's name and the month. Set sharing to "anyone with the link can view". Test the link on a phone that is not signed into your account.

**CHECK** A friend opens the link on their own phone and finds the newest file in under fifteen seconds without your help. If they cannot, rename the folders until they can.

## 3.7 Phone versus laptop, step by step

| STEP | ON A PHONE | ON A LAPTOP |
|---|---|---|
| Folders and naming | Fine. Use the Google Drive app and rename files as you save them | Faster for bulk renaming and moving many files |
| Brand kit page | Fine. Build it in the design app as a normal design | Easier to keep a permanent reference page open beside your work |

| STEP | ON A PHONE | ON A LAPTOP |
|---|---|---|
| Working from a template | Fine for one-page pieces and social posts | Much better for multi-page documents and precise alignment |

| STEP | ON A PHONE | ON A LAPTOP |
|---|---|---|
| Editing photographs | Fine. Phone cameras and simple apps are enough for social and product shots | Better for batch colour correction across ten product images |
| Adding long text (menu, price list) | Possible up to about twenty items; typing long text on a phone is slow and error-prone | Strongly recommended. Type the text on the laptop, or write it in a notes file first and paste |
| Resizing to other formats | Fine with the tool's resize feature, plus manual fixes | Faster when you need five versions of the same design |

| STEP | ON A PHONE | ON A LAPTOP |
|---|---|---|
| Exporting PNG and JPG | Fine | Fine, with more control over compression |
| Exporting print PDF with bleed | Often limited. Some mobile versions cannot set bleed or exact page size | Needed for professional print files |
| Compressing files | Fine using export quality settings | Better for batch compression |
| Uploading and sharing | Fine for previews; large uploads can fail on a weak connection | More reliable for large print files |
| Delivering to the client | Fine. Send the folder link and one preview image | Fine. Do not send twenty attachments either way |

If you have no laptop: keep print jobs to single-page items, and use one paid hour at an internet cafe or a borrowed laptop to produce the final print PDF. Budget that hour into your delivery time.

04

SECTION FOUR

# Your Portfolio: Ten Pieces, No Clients

Exactly what to make for ten portfolio pieces, how to label every one honestly, how to handle an unsolicited redesign of a real business, and how to package it as a one-page PDF and a phone-friendly folder link.


01 The ten pieces, brief by brief

02 The labelling rule that keeps you honest

03 The before/after redesign, done properly

04 One-page PDF portfolio and a folder link that opens on a phone

You cannot sell design without showing design, and waiting for your first client is a slow way to get your first client. So you build the work first: ten finished pieces, each one labelled honestly as a sample.

This is the most valuable two weeks of work in the course. Nobody can take these files away from you, and they answer the only question a buyer really has: can this person make something that looks good?

## 4.1 The labelling rule

**SAY IT PLAINLY, EVERY TIME**

Every portfolio piece you have not been paid for carries the line: **Sample — created by [your name] for demonstration**. Put it in the corner of the image or in the caption underneath. Never imply a fictional shop is a client. Never imply a real business hired you when it did not. The label costs you nothing and protects everything: the moment one client discovers you invented a customer, every other piece of your portfolio becomes suspect.

## 4.2 The ten pieces

Each piece below has a brief you can finish in one sitting. Do them in this order. If a piece takes more than three hours at your current skill level, do the simple version and move on; you can rebuild it later.

### Piece 1 — Café flyer

**Brief:** a fictional café in the commercial district is launching a breakfast menu. **Make:** one A5 flyer, single side. **Content:** shop name, one headline, three menu items with example prices, opening hours, phone number, one real photograph of coffee or food that you took yourself. **Rules used:** two fonts, two colours plus white, one clear margin. **Time:** 45 minutes. **Quality bar:** a stranger can say what the offer is after three seconds.

### Piece 2 — Restaurant menu

**Brief:** a fictional juice house with sixteen items. **Make:** one A4 menu, single page. **Content:** categories (juices, hot drinks, snacks), item names, example prices, one line about the shop. **Extra task:** type the full item list in a notes file first, then paste it in. This is the piece that teaches you alignment and spacing. **Time:** 90 minutes. **Quality bar:** every price lines up in one column and no two lines touch.

### Piece 3 — Clothing-store social pack

**Brief:** a fictional clothing shop needs three square posts. **Make:** a new-stock post, a price-offer post, and a greeting post. **Content:** three different layouts that clearly belong to one brand: same colours, same fonts, same corner treatment. **Time:** 90 minutes. **Quality bar:** the three look like siblings, not strangers.

### Piece 4 — Event invitation

**Brief:** a fictional graduation dinner, or a fictional small conference. **Make:** one portrait invitation, screen version only. **Content:** who, what, where, when, dress or entry note, one contact. Use centre alignment here, and give it generous white space. **Time:** 45 minutes. **Quality bar:** every name, date and time checked twice out loud against the source text.

### Piece 5 — Business card

**Brief:**
**Make:**
**Content:**
**Extra task:Time:Quality bar:**

### Piece 6 — Gym poster

**Brief:** a fictional fitness centre with a new-year offer. **Make:** one A3 or A2 poster. **Content:** one huge headline, one offer line, price, location, phone. Nothing else. **Extra task:** stand three metres from your phone screen and read it. **Time:** 40 minutes. **Quality bar:** readable from across a room with no squinting.

### Piece 7 — Tour-operator brochure cover

**Brief:** a fictional tour operator in a regional city or a regional city offering a three-day trip. **Make:** one brochure cover, plus a matching back page with contact details. **Content:** place name, trip length, three highlights, logo, phone, handle. Use one strong original landscape photograph. **Time:** 60 minutes. **Quality bar:** the cover works as a thumbnail on a phone and as a printed cover.

### Piece 8 — Tutoring-centre presentation cover

**Brief:** a fictional tutoring centre presenting to parents. **Make:** a title slide plus two content slides. **Content:** centre name, subject list, timetable, fees framed as an example, contact. **Time:** 60 minutes. **Quality bar:** one idea per slide and text big enough for the back of a room.

### Piece 9 — Product-graphic set

**Brief:** ten cleaned, branded product images for a fictional seller. **Make:** photograph five real objects (a shoe, a jar, a scarf, a phone case, a bag) twice from different angles in daylight near a window. Then remove or clean the background, place each on the same background colour, add a small brand mark and a price label in the same position on all ten. **Time:** 2 hours. **Quality bar:** all ten images have the same background, the same label position and consistent brightness.

### Piece 10 — Before/after redesign concept

**Brief:** pick one real local business with visibly weak visual material: a menu photographed crookedly, a flyer with nine fonts, a page with no posts for months. **Make:** a single image showing their existing piece on the left and your redesign concept on the right. **Rules:** ask permission before you publish it, never use their logo as if you own it, and label it exactly **Unsolicited redesign concept — not commissioned, not affiliated**. If they say no, take it down and use a fictional brand instead. **Time:** 90 minutes. **Quality bar:** the improvement is obvious to someone who knows nothing about design.

> **PERMISSION, CREDIT AND TAKEDOWN**
>
> Ask in writing, keep the reply, and honour a no immediately. Do not put a real business's name in your portfolio with wording that suggests a working relationship. Do not publish a redesign of a business that has had bad news, a closure or a dispute. If you ever cannot remember whether you had permission, remove the piece and replace it with a fictional one.

## 4.3 One-page PDF portfolio and a folder link

You need two versions of the same portfolio: one link you can send in a message, and one page a client can scan in ten seconds.

1. **Build the folder first**

   One Google Drive folder called `[Your name] – Design Portfolio`. Ten files only, named `01-cafe-flyer.png` through `10-redesign-concept.png`. Set view access for anyone with the link. Nothing else in the folder.

2. **Export a small preview of each piece**

   Longest side around 1200 pixels, JPG, moderate quality. Ten previews should total under 5 MB so the folder opens on a weak connection.

3. **Assemble the one-page PDF**

   A single A4 page with a 2 × 5 grid of thumbnails, your name, your phone, your handle, one line about what you do and who you do it for. If the mobile tool cannot make a multi-image PDF, make one image that contains the grid and export it as a PDF or a single JPG.

4. **Write the caption line once**

   "Samples created by [your name] for demonstration. Full portfolio: [link]." Paste it under every piece you post.

5. **Test it on someone else's phone**

   Send the link to a friend on a different network. If it takes more than a few seconds to open, reduce the preview sizes.

My portfolio folder link .....

Total size of my previews .....

Pieces finished (out of 10) .....

Permission asked for the redesign .....

**WHAT TEN PIECES REALLY BUY YOU**

Not clients, on their own. What they buy is the ability to answer "send me examples" in ten seconds instead of ten minutes, which is the difference between a conversation and silence. Expect some people to look and not reply. That is normal and it is not feedback about your work.

05

SECTION FIVE

# Pricing and Ten Sample Service Packages

How to build a price from your own hours, then adjust it for the size and value of the client, followed by ten ready service packages with contents, example prices in dollars, delivery times, revision allowances and the buyer each one is designed for.


01 Price from hours, then adjust for the client

02 Deposits, what is included, and what is not

03 The ten packages in full

04 The package ladder: how one small job becomes a retainer

05 When and how to raise your prices

A price list is not greed. It is the thing that lets you answer a client in one message instead of haggling in twelve. This section gives you ten packages you can quote today, and the arithmetic behind them so you can build your own.

Every number here is an **example price for teaching**. There is no verified published local rate card for design, so treat these as a starting position to test and adjust, never as a market truth.

## 5.1 Price from your hours, not from your feelings

**EXPLAIN** Beginners price by guessing what the client will tolerate. That produces random prices and resentment. Instead: decide an example hourly figure, estimate the hours honestly including messages and revisions, multiply, add a buffer, then round up to a clean number.

**SHOW** **Example scenario — fictional.** A fictional café flyer takes 1.5 hours to design, 30 minutes of messages, and 30 minutes of revisions. At an example $2 per hour that is $750, plus a 25% buffer for admin and surprises, rounded up to **$6**.

**DO** Time yourself on your next three pieces. Write the real number of minutes, including the messages. Most beginners discover they estimated half the true time.

**CHECK** Your price covers your hours, your data, your transport to the print shop, and the risk of one extra revision. If it does not, it is not a price, it is a discount you did not agree to.

**EXAMPLE ARITHMETIC — NOT A MARKET RATE**

```
2.0 h design + 0.5 h messages + 0.5 h revisions = 3.0 h
3.0 h × $2 = $6
+ 25% buffer = $1,125 → rounded $8
```

The hourly figure is an example you choose for yourself. Check it against what local businesses say they currently pay before you commit to it.

### Then adjust for the client, not for your mood

| ADJUSTMENT | WHEN IT APPLIES | HOW MUCH, AS AN EXAMPLE |
|---|---|---|
| Client size | A hotel, clinic chain or established retailer versus a single kiosk | Charge more for larger clients; they have more at stake and more approvals |
| Commercial value | The piece will be printed in thousands or run as a paid advert | Charge more. Your work is doing sales work |
| Speed | The client needs it tomorrow | Add a rush amount, and say the number before you start |
| Volume | Ten posts in one job rather than one | Charge less per post, but a higher total |
| Repeat business | A monthly retainer rather than one job | Give a small discount in exchange for a predictable month |
| Content burden | The client sends nothing and you must write all the text and take the photographs | Charge more, or make it a separate line item |
| Your own portfolio need | Almost never | Work free only if you would do it for yourself anyway, and cap it at one small piece |

## 5.2 Deposits, inclusions and the awkward questions

**What to agree before you start**

— Total price, in dollars, in writing
— Delivery date and time of day
— How many revision rounds are included
— What the client must send you and by when
— The file formats you will deliver
— Whether printing is included (usually it is not)

**A workable payment structure, as an example**

— **50% before you start** — protects your time on a new client
— **50% on delivery** — before the final high-resolution files are handed over
— For retainers: paid at the start of each month
— For very small jobs, ask for the full amount up front
— Watermark or downsized previews until the balance is paid

**SAY THE DEPOSIT RULE BEFORE THE WORK, NOT AFTER**

Asking for a deposit after you have already designed three drafts is a negotiation you will lose. Put it in the first message: "Fifty percent to start, fifty percent when you approve the final file." Clients who refuse a deposit on a first job are the clients who do not pay at the end.

## 5.3 The ten packages

Each package below is a complete, quotable product. Copy the contents of the ones you want into your own price list, change the group name, and keep the structure.

| PACKAGE | WHAT IS INCLUDED | EXAMPLE PRICE | DELIVERY | REVISIONS | IDEAL BUYER |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **1. Starter** | 5 social graphics, one size, client supplies photos | $16 | 3 days | 1 round | A small shop testing whether design helps |
| **2. Standard** | 15 social graphics, square and vertical versions | $35 | 5 days | 2 rounds | A business already posting weekly |
| **3. Business** | 30 social graphics, mixed formats, a simple content plan | $9,500 | 8 days | 2 rounds | An active brand, gym, restaurant or retailer |
| **4. Menu design** | One menu, up to 40 items, print-ready PDF plus screen version | $22 | 4 days | 2 rounds | Restaurant, juice house, hotel, cafeteria |
| **5. Café opening kit** | Simple logo lockup, flyer, 10 posts, one menu board | $75 | 8–10 days | 3 rounds | A business opening in the next month |

| PACKAGE | WHAT IS INCLUDED | EXAMPLE PRICE | DELIVERY | REVISIONS | IDEAL BUYER |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **6. Invitation pack** | One invitation, screen version plus print file, one reminder graphic | $12 | 2 days | 1 round | Families, graduations, small conferences |
| **7. Product graphics** | 10 cleaned, branded product images on one background | $19 | 4 days | 1 round | Clothing, cosmetics, electronics, online sellers |

| PACKAGE | WHAT IS INCLUDED | EXAMPLE PRICE | DELIVERY | REVISIONS | IDEAL BUYER |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **8. Card and letterhead** | Business card front and back, one A4 letterhead, print files | $16 | 3 days | 2 rounds | Consultants, agents, tradespeople, clinics |

| PACKAGE | WHAT IS INCLUDED | EXAMPLE PRICE | DELIVERY | REVISIONS | IDEAL BUYER |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| **9. Poster and banner** | One poster or banner artwork plus print-ready file | $19 | 3 days | 2 rounds | Events, campaigns, gyms, churches, shops |
| **10. Monthly retainer** | 20 graphics plus 2 video covers each month | $55 / month | Monthly | 1 round per piece | Any business that wants to stop thinking about content |

All prices are **examples to adjust**, not market rates and not quotations. Prices exclude printing unless you agree otherwise. Confirm with the print shop before quoting a client a printed price.

### Notes that make each package work

— **Starter:** the point of this package is a paid yes and a testimonial, not the money. Deliver it fast and deliver it clean.

— **Standard and Business:** these are where most income sits. Sell them as "one month of content", because that is what the client is really buying: the problem removed from their week.

— **Menu design:** the highest-risk package in the list. Every price, item and spelling must be checked against the client's written list, and fasting or seasonal menus should be planned in advance.

— **Café opening kit:** the best-value package for you, and the most demanding. Only offer it once you have finished your ten portfolio pieces.

— **Invitation pack:** sensitive work. Names, dates and spelling are the whole job. Never rush it.

— **Product graphics:** ten images on one consistent background is the single most useful thing a small online seller can buy. Consistency is the product.

— **Poster and banner:** most of your time goes on finding out the exact print size. Ask the printer first.

— **Monthly retainer:** a "video cover" here means a designed cover image for a video, not video editing. If you do not make video content, swap the two video covers for two extra graphics and say so in the package.

## 5.4 The package ladder

**EXPLAIN** A client rarely starts with a retainer. They start with one small piece, and they move up only after you deliver exactly what you promised. Your job is to make each step obvious.

**SHOW** **Example scenario — fictional.** City Fitness Center (fictional gym in the eastern district) buys one poster at $19. You deliver a day early with a print-ready file and a small preview image. At handover you say: "If you want, next month I can do the Starter pack of five posts at $16 so the offer keeps running online." Two months later they are on the Business package.

**DO** Write the one sentence you will say at every handover that offers the next step. Keep it in your notes so you do not have to invent it while the client is standing in front of you.

**CHECK** Every finished job ends with you offering one specific next package, in writing, on the same day you deliver.

## 5.5 When to raise your prices

— After your first five paid jobs, if you finished every one on time and with fewer than three rounds.

— When you are turning work away, or when a new enquiry arrives while you are already at capacity.

— When your client's business grows: a shop that opened one branch and now has three is not the same client.

— After a fixed period, because costs rise. your country's headline inflation was 15.1% year on year in August 2026 and education inflation 25.3%, so a price list left unchanged for a year is a price cut.

— Never in the middle of a running job. Finish it at the agreed price, then quote the new price for the next one.

**HOW TO ANNOUNCE A NEW PRICE WITHOUT LOSING THE CLIENT**

"Selam [name]. From [month] my package prices are changing a little. Your current job stays at the agreed price. From next month, the Standard pack is [new price] instead of [old price]. I am telling you now so you can plan. Thank you for the work this year." Short, early, no apology, no long explanation.

My example hourly figure .....

My three chosen packages .....

My deposit rule .....

My revision allowance .....

My price review date .....

06

SECTION SIX

# Revisions, Feedback and Not Going Crazy

A one-sentence revision policy, how to ask for feedback that is actually useful, the three-revision rule, charging for extra rounds, and what to do when the client prefers their nephew's design. Includes four copy-ready messages.


01 The revision policy in one sentence

02 How to ask for feedback you can act on

03 The three-revision rule and charging for extra rounds

04 The nephew problem, and other opinions in the room

05 Copy-ready messages: feedback, pushback, delivery, closing

Most beginner designers do not lose money on design. They lose it on revisions: eleven rounds, three weeks, and a client who still is not sure. This section fixes that with one sentence and four messages.

## 6.1 The revision policy, in one sentence

**YOUR POLICY, LEARNED BY HEART**

**"Two rounds of revisions are included in the price; further rounds are charged at [example amount] per round, and each round means one round of collected comments, not one change at a time."**

Say it before the work starts, in the same message as the price. Say it politely, once, and then apply it without arguing. A policy you do not enforce is a policy the client will not believe.

The last part of that sentence does the heavy lifting. **One round means one collected list of comments.** If a client sends you a change on Monday, another on Tuesday and a third on Wednesday, that is three rounds in practice, and most beginners absorb all three silently. Say instead: "Send me your full list and I will do it all in one pass."

## 6.2 How to ask for feedback you can act on

**EXPLAIN** "What do you think?" invites an opinion you cannot use. "Which of these three do you prefer, and why?" invites a decision. You are not asking for approval, you are asking for a choice between options you already control.

**SHOW** **Example scenario — fictional.** You send a fictional restaurant owner three menu headers: one with a large the local language headline, one with a large photograph, one with the shop's logo first. You ask which one suits the shop and why. They choose in one message. If you had sent one option, you would have received "change the colour" and no direction.

**DO** For your next delivery, prepare three variants of the single most important element: the headline, the image treatment or the layout. Send them side by side in one image so the client compares like with like.

**CHECK** The client's reply is a decision ("the second one") rather than a feeling ("it is nice but"). If you get a feeling, ask the narrowing question: "Between these two, which should I develop?"

**Questions that get useful answers**

- Which of these three do you prefer, and why?
- Is the price or the offer more important to show first?
- Who is this going to, and what should they do after seeing it?
- Should the local language or the English lead?
- Is any name, price, date or phone number wrong?

**Questions that waste a week**

— What do you think?

— Is it okay?

— Do you like it?

— Should I make it nicer?

— Any comment? (Sent alone, after which nothing arrives and the project stalls.)

## 6.3 The three-revision rule

Track every round in writing. A simple notes file per client is enough: date, what was asked, what you changed. The rule works like this.

1. **Round 1 — the real corrections**
   Wrong price, wrong phone number, wrong date, wrong shop name. These are errors and facts. Fix them immediately, no discussion, no charge.

2. **Round 2 — the genuine preferences**
   Colour direction, photograph choice, headline wording. Included. Ask for the full list at once and do it in one pass.

3. **Round 3 — the last included round**
   Small adjustments after they have seen round 2. Say clearly: "This is the last round included in the price. After this, further rounds are [example amount]."

4. **Round 4 and beyond — charge, politely**
   Do not refuse. Quote the extra-round price in the same calm way you quoted the job, and wait for a yes before starting. Half of clients will suddenly become decisive. The other half will pay, which is fair, because you are still working.

> **THE CHURN WARNING SIGN**
>
> If a client has asked for more than six rounds and no round has made them happier, the problem is not the design. Something upstream is undecided: the price, the offer, or who in the family has final say. Stop designing and ask one question: "Who else needs to approve this before we finish, and what does that person want to see?"

## 6.4 The nephew problem, and other opinions in the room

It will happen. You deliver a clean flyer, and the client's nephew, who has a free design app and an opinion, produces something with nine effects. The client loves it.

**Do**

— Stay calm and stay professional. This is a business decision, not a judgment on you.

— Ask one question: "Would you like me to work from his layout, or keep my version as a base?"

— If they choose his, deliver what they asked, take your agreed payment for the work already done, and leave the door open.

— Send a short closing message and keep them on your list for two months from now.

**Do not**

— Argue about taste. You will lose a client and gain nothing.

— Say "that is wrong" about someone's relative's work.

— Hand over your working files for free as a goodbye.

— Post about it on social media. Shops talk to other shops, and the story that travels is the one where you were difficult.

**THE HONEST FRAMING THAT OFTEN SAVES THE JOB**

"Both versions can work. His is more decorative; mine is built so the price and the phone number are the first things a customer sees. Tell me which one you want to run, and I will make that one as strong as I can." Clients respond to a straight comparison far better than to a defence of your taste.

## 6.5 Copy-ready messages

**COPY-READY: ASKING FOR FEEDBACK**

Selam [name], here are three versions of the [flyer headline]. Option 1 puts the price first. Option 2 puts the photograph first. Option 3 is the most text-light.

Which one do you prefer, and why? Once you choose, I will build the full [flyer] on that direction.

If you can, send all your comments in one message so I can do them in one pass.

**COPY-READY: PUSHING BACK POLITELY ON SCOPE**

Selam [name], thank you, I can do that.

One thing so we stay on schedule: the price includes [two] rounds of revisions. This request would be round [four]. I am happy to do it for [example amount] USD, which covers the extra time, or we can finish the current version as agreed and start this as a new piece next week.

Tell me which you prefer and I will start straight away.

### COPY-READY: DELIVERING THE FINAL FILES

Selam [name], your files are ready.

Folder: [link]
Inside you will find:
1. `Previews` — small images you can open quickly, for your own use.
2. `Print files` — the PDF for the printer, at the size we agreed with [print shop].
3. `Social versions` — square and vertical images for posting.

Please open the preview first and confirm. Once you confirm, I will send the final high-resolution files. The printer can work directly from the PDF in the folder.

### COPY-READY: CLOSING A PROJECT PROPERLY

Selam [name], thank you for the work. The project is complete and the final files are in the folder: [link].

Please keep that folder. I will keep a copy for [six] months in case you need a different size or a reprint.

Two small things: if you are happy with the result, a short message I can show to other clients would help me a lot. And if you want ongoing posts, the [Starter pack] is [example price] USD per month — just tell me when you want to start.

### THE TESTIMONIAL SENTENCE TO ASK FOR

Do not ask for "a testimonial". Ask for one sentence that answers: what did I make, and did it arrive when I said it would? Most people will write that in thirty seconds. Vague requests get ignored; specific ones get answered.

07

SECTION SEVEN

# Finding local Clients

Where design buyers actually look: Instagram, Facebook groups, Telegram channels, LinkedIn for business clients, Google Maps by district and category, a local classifieds site, an online business directory and an online business directory directories, and the underrated channels of print shops, event planners, photographers and referrals. Plus how the same method works with less competition outside Addis.


01 The one method: a prospect list with the gap written next to it

02 Instagram, Facebook, Telegram and LinkedIn

03 Google Maps by district and category

04 a local classifieds site, an online business directory, an online business directory: directories that pay off slowly

05 The best channel nobody uses: print shops

06 Event planners, photographers and referrals

07 Selling outside your city

You are not looking for "clients". You are looking for businesses with a visible, specific gap in how they present themselves, and a reason to fix it this month. That is a list, not a feeling, and you can build it in an afternoon.

Before you start: only 9.80 million social media identities exist where you live, against a population of 136 million, and around 107 million people are offline. Instagram's advertising reach is about 1.55 million people. So an online-only plan reaches a small slice of the market. The businesses you want may be on Instagram, but the person who pays is often reachable by a phone call, a walk-in or a print shop introduction.

## 7.1 The method: a list with the gap written next to it

**EXPLAIN** Every prospect gets a row: business name, category, area, contact, the channel you found them on, **the specific gap you can see**, and the package that fixes it. The gap is what turns a cold message into a relevant one.

**SHOW** A real gap looks like this: "menu board photographed at an angle in 2023, no prices, last Instagram post four months ago, phone number not in the bio." That is not an insult, it is a job description. Your message can quote it back.

**DO** Build a sheet today with these columns: *Business, Category, Area, Contact, Channel, The gap, Package to offer, Date contacted, Follow-up date, Result*. Fill twenty rows. Twenty rows is one evening of work and one week of outreach.

**CHECK** Every row has a gap written in your own words. If a row says "needs design", it is not a prospect yet, because you cannot write a specific message about it.

My weekly prospecting target .....

Areas I will cover first .....

Categories I know best .....

## 7.2 Instagram, Facebook, Telegram and LinkedIn

### 01 Instagram — where design buyers look

Clothing shops, beauty brands, cafés, restaurants, gyms, photographers and event businesses live here, and they judge each other's pages. Ad reach is about 1.55 million people, so this is a small, specific audience rather than a mass market.

- Search a location tag for your area and scroll the businesses, not the influencers.
- Look for pages where posts stop for months, or where the grid is inconsistent.
- Check whether the phone number is in the bio. If it is missing, that is a two-minute fix you can mention.
- Message from your own account with a real profile picture and your portfolio link in the bio.

### 02 Facebook groups — where owners ask questions

Facebook remains the largest social surface where you live, with around 9.80 million ad reach. Groups for business owners, buy-and-sell groups, and city or neighbourhood groups are where people post "who can design a flyer?"

- Join five groups where your buyers already are, not five designer groups.
- Answer questions for a month before you sell anything in the group.
- When someone asks for design help publicly, answer publicly with a sample, then move to private messages.

### 03 Telegram — channels and marketplaces

Telegram is where local business conversations actually happen: shop channels, marketplace groups, job and gig channels, and neighbourhood buy-and-sell groups.

- Follow the marketplace and business channels in your city and watch for new sellers.
- Post your samples in channels that allow it, with your portfolio link and one clear offer.
- Keep your profile name and photo professional. Your Telegram handle is a business card here.
- Expect the account-takeover scam described in the anti-scam section. Never share a one-time code, and turn on two-step verification.

### 04 LinkedIn — for business clients

your country has around 1.80 million LinkedIn members and the platform grew about 38.5% year on year, so it is smaller than Instagram but far better for companies, consultancies, NGOs and training providers that pay properly.

- Write a headline that says what you make, not "graphic designer": "I design menus, flyers and monthly social packs for Addis businesses".
- Connect with marketing officers, founders and admin managers, not with other designers.
- Post one finished sample a week with a short explanation of the problem it solved.

## 7.3 Google Maps by district and category

Google Maps is the main discovery surface for local businesses, which makes it the most reliable prospecting tool you have. your city has ten sub-cities: **the commercial district, the central district, the eastern district, the old town, the northern district, the western district, the outer district, the industrial district, the market district and the busiest district**. Work one district at a time, one category at a time.

1. **Pick a district and a category**

   For example: the commercial district, and restaurants. Or the central district, and clothing shops. Not "your city" and "businesses".

1. **Open the first twenty results**
   For each one, look at three things: the photos (are the menu photos readable?), the hours and phone number (are they missing?), and any social link.
1. **Write the gap in your sheet**
   One line per business, in your own words. Note the package that fixes it.
2. **Move to the next district when you have twenty**
   Twenty rows per area is plenty. Do not collect two hundred names and message none of them.

**WHY THIS BEATS SCROLLING INSTAGRAM**

On Google Maps you can see businesses that have already decided to be found: they have a listing, hours and photos. They care about how they look. Those are the buyers. Businesses with no online presence at all are usually not ready to pay for design, though they may be ready for a printed flyer, which is why the print shop channel matters.

## 7.4 Directories that pay off slowly

| SOURCE | WHAT IT GIVES YOU | HOW TO USE IT |
|---|---|---|
| a local classifieds site | Live classifieds with prices in dollars, filtered by Addis sub-cities, including a services section | Watch for new sellers and shops listing products with weak photos. Product graphics is an easy first sale |
| an online business directory | Around thirty categories with counts, including restaurants and cafés, professional services, factories and construction, plus a fourteen-city filter | Use the category counts to choose a niche with enough buyers, and the city filter for regional work |
| an online business directory | More than ten thousand listed companies, with a free "add your business" option | List yourself for credibility, and use it for company names to search on other channels |
| Chamber and association lists | Around twelve chambers and six associations with phone numbers | Not a prospect list. Use it to find an association that will let you speak or post to members |

Directory counts are from the sources listed in Sources & Further Reading for September 2026. Directories go stale; verify a business is still active before you spend time on it.

## 7.5 The best channel nobody uses: print shops

**EXPLAIN** Every business that needs a flyer, a menu board, a banner or a business card eventually walks into a print shop. The person behind the counter sees all of them, every week, and knows which ones are struggling with their files.

**SHOW** **Example scenario — fictional.** You visit three print shops in the market district with your one-page portfolio. You leave your phone number and offer a simple deal: if a customer arrives with a Word document or a phone photo of a menu, the shop passes your number on. When a job comes to you, you deliver the print-ready file to the same shop.

**DO** Visit three print shops this week. Ask the six questions from Section 02. Then show your portfolio on your phone and ask: "Do customers ever come to you with files that are not ready to print?" Leave your number written on paper, not only in their phone.

**CHECK** Three shops know your name, have your portfolio link, and know what you charge for a flyer and a menu. Then visit them again in two weeks. This channel is built on repetition, not on one visit.

**WHY PRINT SHOPS SEND WORK**

A print shop earns money when a file prints cleanly on the first attempt. A customer with a broken file wastes the shop's time. A designer whose files print correctly saves the shop money, so a sensible shop will recommend you. Offer them something in return: fast turnaround, files that never come back with problems, and a small thank-you for a real referral, in whatever form you both agree in advance.

## 7.6 Event planners, photographers and referrals

**Event planners**

They need invitations, programmes, banners and backdrops, often at short notice, and they work with the same families and companies repeatedly. One good planner is a year of work.

**Photographers**

They already have the photographs and the client relationship, but often no time for layout. Offer to design the album cover, the graduation banner or the social post from their shoot.

**Referrals**

The cheapest client is the one another client sends. Ask for the referral on the day you deliver, when they are happiest, and make it easy: "If you know one shop that needs this, send them my link."

**NEVER BUY FOLLOWERS, REVIEWS OR ENGAGEMENT**

It is a scam, it damages the account, and any client who checks properly will see it. Growth from fake numbers does not produce a single paying client, and it makes your portfolio numbers meaningless. See the anti-scam section at the back.

## 7.7 Selling outside your city

Design supply is concentrated in Addis, and demand is everywhere. If you are in a regional city, a regional city, a regional city, a regional city, a regional city, a regional city or a regional city, the same method works with less competition, and you have two advantages: you can walk into businesses that nobody is messaging, and you can charge less than an Addis agency while still earning well locally.

- **Local walk-ins still work.** Shops, hotels, clinics, colleges and tour operators in regional cities often receive no design pitches at all.
- **Use the city filters.** The an online business directory business guide has a fourteen-city filter; a local classifieds site has regional sections. Both are free ways to build a list.
- **Sell remotely to Addis.** A folder link, a preview image and a phone call are enough. You do not need to be in the same city to design a menu. Be explicit about delivery times and about who prints.
- **Tourism and hospitality pay.** a regional city, a regional city, Lalibela, a smaller town and a regional city have hotels, lodges and tour operators with real marketing budgets and weak visual material.
- **Plan for connectivity problems.** your country scored 30 out of 100 in Freedom House's Freedom on the Net 2025 and has a recent history of regional shutdowns and slowdowns. Keep your portfolio and price list saved offline on your phone, and keep a phone number and a physical meeting as a fallback for every online channel.

— **Do not promise what your town cannot print.** Ask the local print shop what sizes, papers and quantities it can actually produce before you sell a job that needs a large-format banner.

08

SECTION EIGHT

# Outreach That Works for Design

The "I already made you something" approach with a small clearly-labelled free sample, its limits, and ten copy-ready scripts for Instagram, Telegram, Facebook, print shops, walk-ins, follow-ups, price replies, the too-expensive objection and the referral request.


**01** The method: one small sample, clearly labelled, one time

**02** The limits of free samples, and why they matter

**03** Ten copy-ready scripts

**04** Follow-up rhythm: what to do when nobody replies

Design is one of the few services where you can answer a client's question before they ask it. "Can you do this?" becomes "here is one, do you want the rest?" That is the whole method in this section.

Read the scripts, fill in the placeholders, and send. Ten unsent drafts are worth nothing.

## 8.1 The method

**EXPLAIN** You make **one small piece** for the business before you contact them: a single square post using their own photograph, or a quick redesign of one item from their menu or flyer. You label it clearly, send it once, and ask a small, easy question. You are not offering a free project. You are showing evidence.

**SHOW** **Example scenario — fictional.** A fictional café in the commercial district has a blurred photograph of its juice menu on its page. You rebuild that one menu image as a square post, keep the same items and the same prices, and send it with the caption: "Sample, made by me for demonstration, not a paid job." Then: "If you like it, I can do a set of five posts like this."

**DO** Pick five businesses from your prospect list. Make one small sample for each, under forty minutes each. Label every one. Send all five today.

**CHECK** Each message is under five lines, contains one image, one honest label, and one question with an easy answer. If it contains a price list, it is too long.

## 8.2 The limits — read these before you give work away

### THE RULES OF THE FREE SAMPLE

— **One small piece, one time.** A single post or a single redesign. Never a whole menu, never a full set, never a "quick draft of the poster and the flyer and the banner".

— **Always labelled.** "Sample — created by [your name] for demonstration. Not commissioned."

— **Never remove your label** to make it look like paid work, not even if the client asks. If they want it without the label, they can pay for it.

— **Send it once.** If there is no reply, follow up twice at most, then stop. Do not keep producing more free work for silence.

— **If they want changes to the free sample, that is the start of a paid job.** Say so politely: "Happy to change anything — that would be the paid piece, at [example price]."

— **Keep a limit per month.** Five to ten free samples a month is a marketing cost. Thirty is unpaid work with extra steps.

### WHEN NOT TO SEND A SAMPLE AT ALL

Never send an unsolicited sample to a business in mourning, to a family dealing with a death, or about a religious occasion you do not understand. Never redesign a political campaign, a government office or a sensitive institution without being asked. When in doubt, use a fictional business in your portfolio instead and let the client come to you.

## 8.3 Ten copy-ready scripts

Replace everything inside the highlighted placeholders. Keep messages short. Send one image, not five. Do not send the same text to twenty businesses in a row without changing the first line.

**SCRIPT 1 — INSTAGRAM DM**

Selam [shop name]. I saw the photo of your [juice menu / new stock] on your page and made one version of it as a sample.

Sample — created by [your name] for demonstration, not commissioned. Same items, same prices, just easier to read on a phone.

If you like it, I can do a set of five posts like this for [example price] USD. Want me to send the file?

**SCRIPT 2 — TELEGRAM MESSAGE**

Selam. My name is [your name], I design flyers, menus and social posts for businesses in [area].

I noticed [shop name] posted about [the new branch / the offer last month]. I made one sample post for you so you can see the style. It is labelled as a sample, not a paid job.

Would you like me to send two more versions in the same style?

**SCRIPT 3 — FACEBOOK MESSAGE**

Selam [name], I found [business name] on Facebook and I design printed adverts and social posts here in [city or area].

Your [flyer / menu photos] could work harder with clearer prices and one strong headline. I made one sample of your [flyer] to show what I mean. It is labelled as a sample.

If it is useful, tell me and I will explain how I would do a full set. If not, no problem at all — I will not keep messaging you.

**SCRIPT 4 — WALK-IN TO A PRINT SHOP**

Selam. My name is [your name]. I am a designer, and I want to send you files that print correctly the first time.

Two questions: what bleed and file type do you prefer, and what sizes do you print most often? I will write it down and use it for every job.

Also — when a customer comes in with a Word file or a phone photo they cannot print, I can fix it into a proper file for them. If you pass my number on, I will bring the finished file back to you to print. Here is my portfolio and my price for a flyer and a menu: [link].

**SCRIPT 5 — WALK-IN TO A BUSINESS**

Selam, is the owner here? My name is [your name]. I do design work for shops around here — flyers, menus, and posts for social media.

I made one sample using your [menu / product photo], just to show the idea. It is on my phone, it takes twenty seconds to look at.

If you like it, I can do a set. If not, thank you for your time and I will not take more of it. May I leave my number?

### SCRIPT 6 — FOLLOW-UP ONE

Selam [name], following up once on the sample I sent on [day].

If it is not the right time, that is completely fine. If it is, one question: would you rather start with five posts or with the [menu / flyer] first?

### SCRIPT 7 — FOLLOW-UP TWO, THEN STOP

Selam [name], this is my last message about it so I do not fill your inbox.

The sample is here whenever you want it: [link]. If a holiday or a new offer comes up later and you need design quickly, message me and I will answer the same day.

Thank you and good luck with the shop.

### SCRIPT 8 — PRICE REPLY

Selam [name], thank you for asking. Here is the price for what you described:

[Package name] — [example price] USD.
Includes: [what is included].
Delivery: [number] working days after you send your text and photos.
Revisions: [two] rounds included.
Printing: not included; I can send the print-ready file to [print shop] or to yours.

Fifty percent to start and fifty percent when you approve the final file. Shall I begin with [first step]?

### SCRIPT 9 — THE TOO-EXPENSIVE REPLY

Selam [name], I understand, and thank you for telling me honestly.

Two options: I can do a smaller version — [three] posts instead of [five] for [lower example price] USD. Or, if the budget is not there now, I can hold this design and you message me when it is. No pressure either way.

Which would you prefer?

### SCRIPT 10 — THE REFERRAL REQUEST

Selam [name], thank you for the work — the [menu] is finished and the files are in the folder.

One small favour: do you know one other shop that needs this kind of work? If you send them my link, I will look after them the same way.

Here is the link you can forward: [portfolio link].

## 8.4 Follow-up rhythm and the maths of silence

| DAY | ACTION | WHAT TO EXPECT |
|---|---|---|
| Day 1 | First message with the sample | Most people will not reply. This is normal and it is not personal |
| Day 3 | Follow-up one: one short question | A small number reply here, usually with a question about price |
| Day 10 | Follow-up two: the polite close | Almost nobody replies to this one. It exists to leave the door open |
| Day 60 | A seasonal message when a holiday or season approaches | This is where a surprising amount of work comes from, because timing changed and you did not |

**EXAMPLE ARITHMETIC — NOT A PREDICTION**

```
20 messages → 4 replies → 1 paying job
At $12 that is $0.60 per message sent
```

This is arithmetic to show why volume matters, not a forecast. Your reply rate may be better or worse, and it changes with the quality of your list and your samples.

**What raises your reply rate**

- A specific first line that proves you looked at their business
- One clear, small ask instead of a full proposal
- Sending at a sensible hour, not at midnight
- A profile with a real photo, a clear description and your portfolio link
- Following up once, politely, three days later

**What kills your reply rate**

- The same copy-pasted paragraph to fifty businesses
- A message longer than the screen
- Five attachments before anyone asked for them
- Guilt, pressure or "I really need this work"
- Arguing with a no instead of accepting it

09

SECTION NINE

# Client Management, Delivery and Getting Paid where you live

Onboarding, a one-page scope document, collecting content from a disorganised client, handover folders, testimonials and retainer conversion — followed by the payment routes that are legal and verified for an individual where you live, and the ones that are not.


**01** The four questions that settle it in twenty minutes

**02** Local clients versus international clients

**03** The legitimate routes, in order

**04** What never to do

**05** Tax and registration, honestly

Delivery is where beginners lose money: unpaid invoices, endless scope, files handed over before payment. This section gives you a repeatable process, then the payment facts for your country as they stand in September 2026.

Payment rules change. Verify anything you plan to depend on.

## Getting Paid for Design Work

This is the chapter that decides whether the rest of the book turns into money. It is also the chapter most online advice gets wrong, because most online advice assumes you live in a country with a full set of payment rails. If you do, the short version is at the end of this section. If you do not, the rest of this section is for you.

> **THE ONE RULE THAT PREVENTS ALMOST EVERY PROBLEM**
>
> **Agree the payment route with the client before you agree the price.** Not after the work is done, not in the invoice, not when they ask for your bank details. Before.
>
> A client who cannot pay you the way you need is not a client. They are a conversation. Finding that out on delivery day is the most expensive lesson in this book, and it is entirely avoidable with one question asked early.

## How money actually crosses a border

When a client in another country pays you, the money does not travel directly. It moves through a chain, and every link in that chain is a place where it can stop. Knowing the chain tells you which question to ask.

1. **The client pays something**
   A card, a PayPal balance, a bank transfer, a mobile wallet, a local payment method. What they can use depends on *their* country, not yours.

2. **A processor authorises it**
   Stripe, PayPal, Adyen, a regional gateway. This is where most cross-border problems originate, because processors operate country by country.

3. **A platform holds it**
   If you sell through a marketplace or course platform, they hold the money and pay you later, on their schedule, at their minimum.

4. **It is paid out to you**
   A bank deposit in your local currency, a PayPal transfer, or a wallet credit. **This is the link that fails most often**, and it is the one nobody checks before they start.

**EXPLAIN** Buyer-side and seller-side are independent. What your client can use to pay has nothing to do with what you can receive. A platform can be perfectly good for your buyers and completely useless for paying you.

**SHOW** *Example — fictional.* A writer in Nairobi sells a $25 template pack. Buyers pay by card without difficulty. The platform's payout page then shows one option: PayPal. The writer's PayPal account can send but cannot receive. Fourteen sales, $350, stuck behind a payout route that was never tested.

**DO** Before you build anything, open the payout settings of every platform you are considering and write down, in one sentence, exactly how money would reach your bank account.

**CHECK** Can you name the rail, the currency, the minimum payout and the delay? If any of those four is a guess, you have not finished checking.

## The four questions that settle it in twenty minutes

Do this once per platform. It takes about twenty minutes and it prevents weeks of wasted work.

| QUESTION | WHERE TO LOOK | WHAT A USABLE ANSWER LOOKS LIKE |
|---|---|---|
| **1. Does this platform pay out to my country?** | The platform's own payout-settings page or help article — never a blog post, never a YouTube video | Your country named on the platform's own list, with the payout currency |
| **2. Through which rail?** | The same page | A named method: local bank deposit, PayPal, Payoneer, wallet. "Contact support" is not an answer |
| **3. What is the minimum and the delay?** | The payout help article | A number and a schedule, so you can plan cash flow |
| **4. What does it cost in total?** | The pricing page *and* the fees help article — they often disagree | Platform fee plus processing fee, added together, expressed as a percentage of a typical sale |

**TWO RULES THAT WILL SAVE YOU MONEY**

**Read the payout page, not the signup page.** Almost every platform lets you sign up from almost anywhere. That tells you nothing. The gate is payout.

**Check whether two platforms share a rail.** If two services both pay through the same underlying processor, they are not backups of each other. When that one rail has a problem, both stop at once. Verify the underlying rail, not just the brand on the front.

## Local clients versus international clients

These are two different problems and they need two different answers. Do not let one delay the other.

| | LOCAL CLIENTS | INTERNATIONAL CLIENTS |
|---|---|---|
| **What works** | Bank transfer, mobile wallet, cash, a local card gateway. Almost always available to an individual with no registered business. | A licensed remittance corridor, a platform that pays out to your country, or an employer's own payroll route. |
| **Speed** | Same day, often same hour | Days to weeks, depending on the platform's payout schedule |
| **What can block it** | Nothing much, if you have an account in your own name | Country eligibility, missing documents, a rail that does not reach you |
| **Best first move** | Start here. Local clients pay for your proof. | Test the payout route with a small real payment before you promise anything |

**THE TEST PAYMENT**

Before you quote a single international client, run one small real transaction end to end: sell something cheap — a $5 template, a $10 review, a single small job — and take it all the way to money in your account.

This costs you one afternoon and one small fee. It converts every assumption in this chapter into a fact, and it is the single most useful hour in this entire book.

## What to say to a client about payment

Clients are not suspicious of payment questions. They are suspicious of vague ones. Say the route plainly, in the first conversation, in writing.

**COPY-READY: THE PAYMENT-ROUTING MESSAGE**

Before we start, one practical thing so neither of us has a surprise at the end.

I am paid by [route: bank transfer / a named platform / a licensed transfer service]. The money arrives in [currency], and I can start work as soon as the first payment shows on my side.

If you would rather use a different method, tell me now and I will check whether it works — I would rather spend five minutes on this today than a week on it later.

For [amount] the split is [50] % to start and [50] % on delivery.

**COPY-READY: WHEN A PAYMENT IS LATE**

Hello [name] — checking in on the [amount] for [work], which I sent on [date]. It has not shown on my side yet.

Could you confirm the date it was sent and the reference number? If it has not gone out yet, no problem — just let me know when it will, and I will plan around that.

## Pricing when the route costs money

Cross-border routes cost the sender or the receiver money. Decide who absorbs it before you quote, and put it in the price rather than discovering it later.

**WORKED EXAMPLE — TARGET ARITHMETIC, NOT A FORECAST**

```
Your price for the work: $100
Transfer or platform cost, if you absorb it: $5–$15
What actually reaches you: $85–$95
```

Two ways to handle it: quote a price that already includes the cost, or state plainly that transfer fees are the sender's. What you must not do is quote $100 and then argue about $12 after delivery.

**NEVER DO THESE THINGS, WHATEVER ANYONE TELLS YOU**

— **Never enter a false country, name or address** on a payment platform. It breaches the provider's terms, it usually fails identity verification anyway, and the consequence is a frozen balance and a closed account — with your customers refunded and your earnings gone.

— **Never use a relative's or friend's account abroad** to receive money that is yours. It is the same misrepresentation with extra steps, and it puts their account at risk too.

— **Never use a VPN to open a financial account** in a country you do not live in.

— **Never buy or rent a verified account.** The seller keeps access to it.

— **Never accept payment in a form your country restricts.** Several countries prohibit or restrict virtual-asset transactions; check your own before you accept anything unusual.

The published terms are unambiguous about this. Most platforms require you not to "create an account using a false identity or information, or on behalf of someone other than yourself", and prohibit misrepresenting your "identity, location or credentials". The stated remedy is suspension or termination, and where an underlying processor makes the final call it is often not appealable.

## The legitimate routes, in the order worth trying

| # | ROUTE | WHO IT SUITS | WHAT TO VERIFY FIRST |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | A platform that publishes your country on its own payout list, paying into a local bank account in local currency | Anyone selling digital products or courses | That the payout page offers *bank deposit*, not "PayPal only", for your country |
| 2 | A licensed money-transfer service (Western Union, MoneyGram, Remitly, WorldRemit and similar) for a one-off client payment | Freelancers and service sellers with a single client | That the receiving country and currency appear on the provider's own corridor list |
| 3 | An employer's own payroll or contractor route | Remote employees and long-term contractors | That the employer has paid a contractor in your country before — ask them directly |
| 4 | Registering as an exporter of services and receiving into a foreign-currency account | Anyone earning regularly from abroad | Your own country's rules. In several countries this unlocks full retention of foreign-currency earnings and an international card — ask a local accountant, do not guess |
| 5 | Trading through a properly registered company in the country where the payout account sits | Established sellers doing meaningful volume | Real incorporation, a real bank account there, real accounting, and any home-country approval required. Legitimate, but slow and expensive — not a shortcut |

**IF YOU ALREADY HAVE FULL PAYMENT RAILS**

Then most of this chapter is not your constraint, and your fastest route is whatever your clients already use: Stripe, PayPal, a card gateway. Skim the four verification questions above anyway — the platform fee difference between two similar services is often several percentage points, and on a hundred sales a year that is real money.

## Tax and registration, stated honestly

**THIS IS NOT TAX ADVICE, AND THE RULES ARE LOCAL**

Almost every country requires you to declare income you earn, and most require some form of tax registration once you are trading. What that means in practice — a tax number, a business registration, a turnover-tax threshold, a VAT threshold — differs enormously from country to country, and the thresholds change.

**What to do:** find your national tax authority's own website, look for the page on registering as a sole trader or self-employed person, and read the current threshold. If your earnings are small, you may be below every threshold. If they are not, register. A local accountant charges very little for one hour of advice, and that hour is worth more than any general guidance in a book written for the whole world.

Keep a simple record from your first sale: date, client, amount, currency, what it was for, and the fee deducted. That one sheet makes tax time trivial and makes you look professional if anyone ever asks.

**IF YOU SELL THROUGH A MARKETPLACE, READ THIS**

Large platforms are often the *merchant of record*, meaning they handle sales tax and VAT for the buyer and remit it themselves. That does not remove your obligation to declare the income you receive. It changes what you have to collect, not whether you have to report.

Some platforms also require a tax form before they will pay you at all — a W-9 if you are in the United States, a W-8 series form if you are not, or a local equivalent. If a form is required and not submitted, payouts are usually paused. Complete it early rather than after your first sale.

10

SECTION TEN

# A Fourteen-Day Portfolio Launch Plan

Fourteen days, about two hours a day, ending with ten labelled portfolio pieces, a price list, a prospect list of twenty businesses and twenty outreach messages sent.

01 Days 1–3: setup, rules and the first pieces

02 Days 4–8: finish all ten portfolio pieces

03 Days 9–11: package the portfolio, set prices, build the list

04 Days 12–14: print shops, outreach and the first quotes

Two hours a day. Fourteen days. At the end you will have a portfolio, a price list, a list of twenty real businesses and twenty messages sent. Nothing about this plan depends on a laptop, though a laptop makes days 4, 6 and 9 easier.

If you miss a day, do not restart. Move to the next day and accept the plan taking sixteen days instead of fourteen.

## DAY 01 Set up the workspace

**OBJECTIVE** Have a working folder system, a design tool, and a written target.

**TASK** Install or open your free design tool. Create the master folder and four subfolders from Section 03. Fill in the worksheet at the end of the front matter, including the three business types you know best.

**EXAMPLE** `DESIGN WORK / 2026-09 Practice / 02-working` — one folder, clearly named, is the whole system.

**OUTPUT** A folder structure and a written target for the fourteen days.

**CHECK**

- [ ] The design tool opens and exports a test image
- [ ] Folders exist with the naming format from Section 03
- [ ] My target is written down in one sentence

## DAY 02 Learn the six rules by rebuilding something bad

**OBJECTIVE** Feel the difference the rules make, in your own hands.

**TASK** Find any cluttered flyer or poster. Rebuild it with two fonts, three colours, one alignment and one margin. Delete at least three elements.

**EXAMPLE** A flyer with nine fonts becomes a flyer with one headline, one offer line and one contact block.

**OUTPUT** One practice piece saved in `02-working`. Not for the portfolio.

**CHECK**

- [ ] Two fonts maximum
- [ ] Three colours maximum
- [ ] Nothing touches the page edge
- [ ] Passes the squint test

## DAY 03 Portfolio pieces 1 and 2

**OBJECTIVE** Two finished pieces: the café flyer and the business card.

**TASK** Follow the briefs in Section 04. Use your own photograph. Label each one **Sample — created by [your name] for demonstration**.

**EXAMPLE** A fictional the commercial district café breakfast flyer, A5, with three items and example prices.

**OUTPUT** Two PNG files named `01-cafe-flyer` and `05-business-card`.

**CHECK**

- [ ] Both carry the sample label
- [ ] Phone number and prices checked twice
- [ ] Readable on a phone at 100%

## DAY 04 Portfolio piece 3 — the menu

**OBJECTIVE** One A4 menu with sixteen items, correctly aligned.

**TASK** Type the whole item list into a notes file first, with prices. Paste it into the design, then align every price into one column and set consistent spacing between groups.

**EXAMPLE** Juices, hot drinks and snacks in three groups, one line of shop information at the top.

**OUTPUT** One menu design, screen version, plus the source text file kept for reuse.

**CHECK**

- [ ] Every price is in one vertical column
- [ ] No two text lines touch
- [ ] Fasting or seasonal items are handled with care
- [ ] Sample label present

## DAY 05 Portfolio pieces 4 and 5

**OBJECTIVE** A three-post clothing pack and an event invitation.

**TASK** Build three posts that clearly belong to one brand: same colours, fonts and corner treatment. Then design one portrait invitation with generous white space.

**EXAMPLE** New stock, price offer, greeting post — three different layouts, one identity.

**OUTPUT** Four files: three posts and one invitation.

**CHECK**

- [ ] The three posts look like siblings
- [ ] Invitation names, date and place checked twice out loud
- [ ] All four labelled as samples

## DAY 06 Portfolio pieces 6 and 7

**OBJECTIVE** A gym poster that works at distance, and a tour-operator brochure cover.

**TASK** One huge headline, one offer line, price, location, phone. Then a brochure cover with place name, trip length and three highlights.

**EXAMPLE** A fictional fitness centre new-year offer, and a fictional three-day a regional city trip.

**OUTPUT** Two files, plus the original photographs you used.

**CHECK**

- [ ] Poster readable from three metres
- [ ] Brochure cover still clear as a phone thumbnail
- [ ] Only one message per piece

## DAY 07 Portfolio pieces 8 and 9

**OBJECTIVE** A presentation cover set and the ten-image product pack.

**TASK** Build a title slide plus two content slides. Then photograph five objects twice in daylight near a window, clean the backgrounds, and place each on the same background with the same label position.

**EXAMPLE** A fictional tutoring centre slide with three subjects and an example fee line.

**OUTPUT** Three slides and ten product images, consistently treated.

**CHECK**

- [ ] One idea per slide
- [ ] All ten product images share one background colour
- [ ] Label position identical in all ten

## DAY 08 Portfolio piece 10 — the redesign concept

**OBJECTIVE** One before/after redesign of a real local business, done properly.

**TASK** Choose a business with a visible gap. Message them asking permission to show a redesign concept. Build the before/after image with the label **Unsolicited redesign concept — not commissioned, not affiliated**.

**EXAMPLE** Left: their crooked menu photograph. Right: the same items, same prices, rebuilt cleanly.

**OUTPUT** One before/after image, plus the permission message sent.

**CHECK**

- [ ] Permission asked in writing
- [ ] Label visible on the image
- [ ] Nothing implies they hired me
- [ ] If they said no, I replaced it with a fictional brand

## DAY 09 Package the portfolio

**OBJECTIVE** A folder link and a one-page PDF you can send in ten seconds.

**TASK** Export small previews of all ten pieces. Build the one-page grid with your name, phone and handle. Set the folder to view access for anyone with the link.

**EXAMPLE** Ten thumbnails, one line: "I design menus, flyers and monthly social packs for Addis businesses."

**OUTPUT** One folder link, one PDF or JPG portfolio page, total preview size under 5 MB.

**CHECK**

- [ ] A friend opens the link on their own phone without help
- [ ] Every piece is labelled as a sample
- [ ] My phone number is correct on the page

## DAY 10 Price list and twenty prospects

**OBJECTIVE** A written price list and a prospect sheet with twenty real businesses.

**TASK** Choose three packages from Section 05 and write your example prices. Then build twenty rows in your sheet using Google Maps, one district and one category at a time.

**EXAMPLE** the commercial district and restaurants: twenty rows, each with the gap written next to the name.

**OUTPUT** Three prices and twenty prospects with contacts and gaps.

**CHECK**

- [ ] Every row has a specific gap written in my own words
- [ ] Every price has a delivery time and a revision allowance
- [ ] I can say my three packages out loud in thirty seconds

## DAY 11 First outreach batch

**OBJECTIVE** Ten messages sent, with five labelled samples attached.

**TASK** Make five small samples: one for each of five prospects. Use Scripts 1, 2 and 3 from Section 08. Send ten messages in total, including five without a sample.

**EXAMPLE** A rebuilt menu post for a fictional café, labelled as a sample, sent with one question.

**OUTPUT** Ten sent messages, logged in the sheet with the date.

**CHECK**

- [ ] Every sample carries the label
- [ ] Every message is under five lines
- [ ] Each message ends with one easy question
- [ ] No message went out twice by accident

## DAY 12 Print shops and walk-ins

**OBJECTIVE** Three print shops and three businesses visited in person.

**TASK** Ask the six print questions from Section 02 at each shop and write the answers down. Then walk into three businesses from your list and use Script 5.

**EXAMPLE** One page in your notes: shop name, contact, bleed, preferred file type, price for 500 A5 flyers, turnaround.

**OUTPUT** Three print shop records and three in-person conversations.

**CHECK**

- [ ] Bleed, size, file type and colour requirements written down
- [ ] My number left in writing, not only in a phone
- [ ] Portfolio link shown on my phone

## DAY 13 Second batch, follow-ups and posting

**OBJECTIVE** Twenty messages sent in total, follow-ups done, three portfolio pieces posted publicly.

**TASK** Send ten more messages. Follow up with the Day 11 batch using Script 6. Post three portfolio pieces on Instagram or Telegram with the sample caption and your folder link.

**EXAMPLE** "Sample created by [name] for demonstration. Full portfolio: [link]. I design menus and monthly social packs."

**OUTPUT** Twenty messages logged, three public posts, follow-ups sent.

**CHECK**

- [ ] Follow-up messages sent exactly once each
- [ ] Every public post is labelled and honest
- [ ] My profile has a real photo and my portfolio link

## DAY 14 Review, quote and plan the next two weeks

**OBJECTIVE** Every reply answered, every quote sent, and a plan for the next fourteen days.

**TASK** Reply to every message, using Scripts 8 and 9. Send at least one written quote. Review your prices after what you learned. Add twenty new prospects to the sheet for next week.

**EXAMPLE** A quote for the Starter pack at your example price with deposit, delivery and revision terms in it.

**OUTPUT** Ten portfolio pieces, a portfolio link, a price list, forty prospects and twenty messages sent.

**CHECK**

- [ ] Every reply answered within a day
- [ ] At least one quote sent in writing
- [ ] Next fourteen days planned, with a weekly target of twenty messages
- [ ] My price review date is in my calendar

**WHAT YOU HAVE AFTER FOURTEEN DAYS**

Ten labelled portfolio pieces, a portfolio link that opens on a phone, a written price list, at least three print shop contacts, forty prospects and twenty messages sent. That is a real position to negotiate from. It is not a business yet, and the plan does not promise clients. What it removes is the reason most people never start: having nothing to show and no idea what to say.

CLOSING

# Common Mistakes and How to Fix Them

Fourteen mistakes that cost local beginner designers money, time or reputation — and the fix for each one.

| MISTAKE | WHAT IT COSTS YOU | THE FIX |
|---|---|---|
| Using five or more fonts in one design | The piece looks unfinished and the client cannot explain why they do not like it | Two fonts. One for headings, one for body text. Delete the rest |
| Text touching the edge of the page | Printers trim it off; phone screens crop it | Keep a margin on all four sides, and ask the printer about bleed before you design |
| Stretching the local language text to fit a space | Broken letterforms that any the local language reader notices immediately | Scale proportionally, change the size, or shorten the words. Never stretch |
| Selling single social posts only | You earn the same small amount forever and start each month from zero | Sell packages of five, fifteen or thirty, then move clients to a monthly retainer |
| Quoting a printed price before asking the print shop | You pay the difference out of your own fee | Ask the six print questions first, then quote with printing listed as a separate line |
| Starting work with no deposit | You finish the work and become the person who has to chase money | Half up front, half on approval, stated before you start |
| Unlimited revisions by habit | One job becomes three jobs at one job's price | Two rounds included, one collected list per round, extra rounds charged at a stated amount |
| Delivering screenshots of your design | Loses quality, cannot be resized, looks amateur | Use the export button. Always |

| MISTAKE | WHAT IT COSTS YOU | THE FIX |
|---|---|---|
| Sending a 40 MB file to a client on a small bundle | The file never opens and the client goes quiet | Send a small preview first, and one folder link for the full files |
| Unlabelled portfolio samples | One discovery of an invented client destroys all your credibility | Label every unpaid piece: "Sample — created by [name] for demonstration" |
| Copying a template exactly | Clients see the same design on three other pages | Replace images, colours, headline and at least two layout elements |
| Ignoring the local language spelling and grammar | The client loses face in front of their customers, and blames you | Read every the local language line out loud, then have a fluent reader check it |

| MISTAKE | WHAT IT COSTS YOU | THE FIX |
|---|---|---|
| Waiting until the portfolio is perfect | Weeks pass with no outreach and no feedback on what buyers actually want | Send with seven pieces, not ten. Improve while you sell |

| MISTAKE | WHAT IT COSTS YOU | THE FIX |
|---|---|---|
| Treating silence as rejection | You stop after twenty messages, right before the list starts working | Send twenty messages a week, every week, and follow up once |

| MISTAKE | WHAT IT COSTS YOU | THE FIX |
|---|---|---|
| Publishing a redesign without permission | A complaint, a takedown, and damage in a small business community | Ask first, keep the reply, label it "unsolicited redesign concept", and honour a no immediately |
| Working with nothing in writing | Disputes you cannot win, because nothing was agreed | One-page scope document, confirmed by a reply that says "agreed" |

CLOSING

# FAQ — Honest Answers

### Do I need to know how to draw?

No. Almost none of the work in this course involves drawing. You arrange text, photographs, colour and space. The one place hand skill helps is a simple logo mark, and even there a clean wordmark in a good font beats a rough drawing.

### Do I need Photoshop?

No, and you should not buy it to start. Photoshop is a photo-editing program; the work in this course is layout work, which is what template-based design tools do. Free tools cover everything in Sections 03 and 04. Free plans change, so check the current limits before you depend on one.

### Can I really design a menu on a phone?

Yes, up to roughly twenty items, if you type the item list in a notes file first and paste it in. Beyond that, precise alignment on a phone becomes slow and error-prone, and this is one of the tasks where a laptop genuinely is better. If you have no laptop, keep the menu to one page and let the print shop typeset a long price list from your clean text file.

### How much do I charge for a flyer?

This course gives an example range of 800 to $9 for a beginner, and it is an example, not a market rate. There is no published local rate card for design that could be verified. The honest method: price from your hours, add a buffer, then ask five local businesses and print shops what they currently pay and adjust to the range you hear.

### What if the client hates it?

Ask three narrowing questions: which of these versions is closest, what should a customer notice first, and is anything factually wrong? Then fix the facts immediately and revise the direction once. If they still hate it after two rounds and cannot say why, the problem is upstream of the design — an undecided price, an undecided offer, or too many people with an opinion. Ask who has final say.

### Do I need the local language fonts?

Yes, if you design anything for the local language-reading audience, which is most local print work. Use a proper a font that supports that script rather than pasting the local language into a Latin-only font, keep the line height generous, and never stretch the letterforms. Confirm that the font you use is licensed for commercial work by checking the tool's own terms.

### Should I buy templates?

You do not need to. The core path in this course uses free templates. A paid template pack is an OPTIONAL upgrade that can save time if it comes with a commercial licence and you understand what you are buying. The free alternative is the tool's own template library plus the six rules in Section 02, applied properly. Never use a template you cannot prove you are licensed to use commercially.

### How do I print?

You design the file, the print shop prints it. Ask the shop six questions before you design: finished size, bleed, file type, colour requirements, price at the client's quantity, and turnaround. Ask for a proof on anything printed in quantity and have the client approve it in writing. Never promise exact colour accuracy.

### Do I need a business licence?

For local clients, no: you can receive payment by person-to-person wallet transfer or bank transfer as an individual, within your regulator limits in Section 09. A merchant payment gateway, however, requires a registered business with a trade licence, TIN and Memorandum of Association, and no verified gateway onboards an unlicensed individual. TIN registration is mandatory, and turnover tax and VAT rules may apply to you. Confirm your own position with your local tax office.

### How do I get paid?

Local clients: wallet or bank transfer, with a written receipt. International clients: through your regulator-licensed remittance corridor such as Western Union, MoneyGram, Ria, Remitly, WorldRemit, Taptap Send, TalkRemit and others, or a wallet corridor. PayPal, Payoneer, Wise and Stripe as a direct receiving rail into your country is not verified, and this course will not pretend otherwise. Crypto is prohibited where you live unless expressly authorised.

### How do I stop twenty free changes?

One sentence, said before the work starts: two rounds included, one collected list of comments per round, extra rounds charged at a stated amount. Then apply it. When a client sends change number eleven, do not argue and do not absorb it silently: quote the extra round, calmly, and wait for a yes.

### Can I do this outside Addis?

Yes, and competition is thinner. a regional city, a regional city, a regional city, a regional city, a regional city, a regional city and a regional city all have hotels, restaurants, shops, colleges and clinics that need this work. You can also sell remotely to Addis with a folder link and a phone call. Check what your local print shops can actually produce before you sell a large-format job, and keep an offline copy of your portfolio because connectivity problems happen.

### Is design not already too cheap?

Single pieces are cheap, yes, and the bottom of the market is crowded. That is exactly why this course pushes packages and monthly retainers rather than competing on the price of one flyer.

The way up is not to design faster for the same money; it is to sell a month of content instead of a file, and to be the person a print shop recommends because your files always print correctly.

### What if nobody replies?

That is the normal starting condition. Twenty messages producing one paying job is a working ratio, and it means the twentieth message is not a failure, it is part of the price of the first. Keep sending twenty a week, keep your list specific, follow up once, and re-contact everyone who said "not now" in two months.

CLOSING

# How to Spot a Fake Opportunity

Designers are targeted because they work for free at the start and want exposure. These are the specific traps, plus the rules that protect you.

## The five traps aimed at designers

| TRAP | HOW IT WORKS | WHAT TO DO |
|---|---|---|
| **Fake design contests** | A page, brand or "agency" announces a contest with a prize. Entries are the prize: they collect fifty designs, use one, and pay nothing | Do not enter contests that require full, unlabelled, ready-to-use work for free. If you want to practise, make samples for yourself and keep the rights |
| **"Premium account" resellers** | Cheap access to a paid design tool, sold on Telegram. Usually a shared or stolen account with someone else's payment card attached | Never use somebody else's account. It can be closed without warning, your files disappear with it, and using it may breach the tool's terms |
| **Subcontracting agencies that vanish** | Someone offers you a big project "for a client abroad", takes your files, and stops answering when payment is due | Deposit first, always, for a new counterparty. Deliver watermarked or downsized previews until paid. Ask for a company name, a phone number and one previous designer you can speak to |
| **Source file before payment** | A client demands the editable file "to check it" before paying, then disappears with it | Decide in advance whether source files are included at all. If they are, they come after full payment. Previews and print-ready PDFs are enough for approval |
| **Buying followers or reviews** | Someone offers to grow your page or add five-star reviews so clients trust you faster | Refuse. Fake numbers produce no paying clients, they breach platform terms, and any client who checks will find out |

## Payment fraud warnings that apply to you directly

**THE YOUR CENTRAL BANK OR FINANCIAL REGULATOR'S WARNING**

The your regulator has publicly warned that fraudsters impersonate people on WhatsApp, Telegram, Facebook, email and SMS, and through fake phone calls, to request urgent transfers. Report suspected fraud to `your regulator's complaint address` or call `6230`. Treat every urgent payment request as fraudulent until you have confirmed it by calling the person on a number you already had.

**THE TELEGRAM ACCOUNT-TAKEOVER SCAM**

local press has documented scammers who pose as Telegram security staff, ask for your password and a one-time code, seize your account, then message your contacts asking for money in your name. Designers are attractive targets because their account holds client conversations and files.

**Nobody legitimate ever asks for your one-time code.** Not Telegram, not a bank, not a wallet, not a "security team", not a client. Turn on two-step verification, keep your phone number current, and if you think your account was taken, tell your clients by phone immediately rather than by message.

**THE OVERPAYMENT REFUND SCAM**

Someone "accidentally" sends you more money than agreed, then asks you to send the difference back to a different number. The original transfer is later reversed or came from a compromised account, and the money you sent is gone. Rule: never refund an overpayment to a third party. Ask the sender to reverse it through their own provider.

### The eight-point legitimacy checklist

Before you accept a client, a "collaboration" or a job offer, work through all eight. If two or more fail, walk away.

- [ ] They can name their business, and it exists when you search for it
- [ ] They are willing to speak on a phone call, not only by text
- [ ] They accept a written scope and a deposit before work starts
- [ ] They never ask for your password, your one-time code, or access to your account
- [ ] They do not ask you to misrepresent where you are, or to use someone else's account or identity
- [ ] They do not propose payment in a form this course has told you is prohibited or unverified
- [ ] Their deadlines are realistic and they answer questions directly
- [ ] Someone you can contact has worked with them before, or they have a verifiable public presence

No checklist proves that a client is honest. It only removes the obvious risks. When money is involved and something feels wrong, slow down and verify. Losing one job costs you a week; losing a month of unpaid work costs you the business.

# Sources & Further Reading

Every platform figure in this book traces to one of the sources below, all checked in September 2026. Platform country lists, payout methods and fees change often — confirm anything you intend to rely on at the source itself.

1. Gumroad — pricing and fee structure — https://gumroad.com/pricing
2. Gumroad — getting paid, bank-payout country list and payout schedule — https://gumroad.com/help/article/13-getting-paid
3. Gumroad — fees in detail — https://gumroad.com/help/article/66-gumroads-fees
4. Gumroad — payout settings, identity documents and tax IDs — https://gumroad.com/help/article/260-your-payout-settings-page
5. Gumroad — account suspension and what causes it — https://gumroad.com/help/article/160-suspension
6. Gumroad — terms of service (identity, location and account rules) — https://gumroad.com/terms
7. Lemon Squeezy — supported countries for sellers — https://docs.lemonsqueezy.com/help/getting-started/supported-countries
8. Lemon Squeezy — W-8 and W-9 tax forms for non-US sellers — https://docs.lemonsqueezy.com/help/tax-forms/w8-w9-forms
9. Lemon Squeezy — pricing — https://www.lemonsqueezy.com/pricing
10. Stripe — cross-border payouts and supported regions — https://docs.stripe.com/connect/cross-border-payouts
11. IRS — About Form W-8BEN — https://www.irs.gov/forms-pubs/about-form-w-8-ben
12. IRS — United States income tax treaties A to Z — https://www.irs.gov/businesses/international-businesses/united-states-income-tax-treaties-a-to-z
13. Whop — payout methods and countries — https://docs.whop.com/manage-your-business/manage-payouts/payout-methods
14. Payhip — how sellers get paid — https://help.payhip.com/article/173-how-do-i-get-paid
15. Ko-fi — how creators get paid — https://help.ko-fi.com/hc/en-us/articles/115003980093-How-do-I-get-paid
16. Fungies — countries you can sell from — https://fungies.io/global-availability/
17. Telegram — Telegram Stars for digital goods — https://telegram.org/blog/telegram-stars
18. Google — Business Profile supported countries — https://support.google.com/business/answer/6270107
19. YouTube — Partner Program availability by country — https://support.google.com/youtube/answer/7101720
20. DataReportal — global digital statistics — https://datareportal.com/reports/digital-2026-global-overview-report
21. World Bank — World Development Indicators — https://databank.worldbank.org/source/world-development-indicators
22. International Labour Organization — ILOSTAT employment data — https://ilostat.ilo.org/
23. Internet Society — Internet shutdown and disruption reporting — https://www.internetsociety.org/
24. FATF — virtual asset and payment-service guidance by jurisdiction — https://www.fatf-gafi.org/

Where research could not verify a fact, this book says so in the text and tells you to check it yourself. Those gaps were left as gaps deliberately.

CLOSING

# Final Checklist

Work down this list. If you can tick everything here, you have done the course.

- [ ] I have a master folder with the Year-Month-Client naming format
- [ ] I have a design tool that exports PNG, JPG and PDF
- [ ] I can name the ten products local clients buy
- [ ] I can explain contrast, alignment, repetition, proximity, white space and hierarchy in my own words
- [ ] Every design I make uses at most two fonts and three colours
- [ ] I check the local language line height and never stretch the fidel
- [ ] I pass the squint test before I send anything
- [ ] I have asked a print shop the six questions and written down the answers
- [ ] I know the finished size and bleed for at least one standard product
- [ ] I have ten labelled portfolio pieces in one folder
- [ ] Every unpaid piece says "Sample — created by [my name] for demonstration"
- [ ] My redesign concept is labelled "unsolicited" and I have permission in writing
- [ ] My portfolio link opens on someone else's phone in a few seconds
- [ ] I have a one-page PDF portfolio with my phone number on it
- [ ] I have a written price list with three packages, delivery times and revision allowances
- [ ] I can say my prices out loud without hesitating
- [ ] I have a prospect sheet with at least twenty businesses and a written gap for each
- [ ] I have sent at least twenty outreach messages
- [ ] I have followed up once, politely, and then stopped
- [ ] I have visited at least three print shops in person
- [ ] I have a one-page scope document ready to send
- [ ] I know how I will receive money: which wallet or bank, and its limits
- [ ] I know that a merchant gateway needs a registered business, and I know where to ask about TIN and tax
- [ ] I know that international clients pay through your regulator-licensed remittance corridor, and that crypto is prohibited
- [ ] I never share a one-time code with anyone
- [ ] I have a written reply ready for "it is too expensive"
- [ ] I have asked one happy client for a referral
- [ ] I have set a date to review my prices

CLOSING

# Final Challenge: Build Your First 10-Piece Design Portfolio

**THE CHALLENGE IN ONE PARAGRAPH**

Ten finished pieces, in one shared folder, every one labelled honestly, plus a one-page portfolio image, a price list of three packages, a prospect list of twenty small local businesses with the gap written next to each, and twenty outreach messages sent. Fourteen days at about two hours a day, or a slower pace if your weeks are full.

## Definition of done

- [ ] Ten pieces exist as finished image or PDF files, not drafts
- [ ] Each piece is named with the format from Section 03
- [ ] Each unpaid piece carries the sample label
- [ ] The redesign piece carries its unsolicited-concept label and permission was asked in writing
- [ ] One folder link opens on a phone in a few seconds, with total previews under 5 MB
- [ ] One page shows the ten thumbnails with your name, phone number and one line about what you do
- [ ] Three packages are written with example prices, delivery times and revision allowances
- [ ] Twenty prospects are listed with a specific gap for each
- [ ] Twenty outreach messages have been sent and logged with dates
- [ ] Every reply has been answered, and at least one written quote has gone out

**WHAT COMPLETING THIS CHALLENGE DOES AND DOES NOT MEAN**

Completing it means you have a real portfolio, a price list and a working outreach habit. That is a genuine asset and most people never build it.

It does **not** guarantee clients, income or replies. Nothing in this course does. The fourteen days produce the work that makes a first conversation possible; the conversations themselves depend on your market, your timing and how many messages you send. Some people finish this and get a paid job in the first week. Some finish it and hear nothing for a month. Both are normal, and neither is a verdict on you.

CLOSING

# Next Steps

Design pays per piece. The courses below are how you turn per-piece work into something steadier, depending on which direction you want to grow.

### 04 Sell monthly, not per piece

If you want retainers instead of one-off jobs, Course 04 covers managing social media accounts for small local businesses: content calendars, posting rhythm, reporting, and the client conversations that hold a monthly fee in place. It is the natural next step after your first three design clients.

### 09 Broaden into a service business

If you want to sell more than design — design plus printing coordination, plus content, plus setup — Course 09 covers building an local online service business: positioning, packaging, pricing, client systems and the legal basics.

### 06 Sell templates instead of only client work

If you would rather make one thing and sell it many times, Course 06 covers selling digital products from a country with limited payment access: what sells, how to package it, how to price it, and how to deliver it without a payment rail you do not have.

### 10 The full build

If you want the whole picture in one place — offer, pricing, clients, delivery, money — Course 10 is the complete build challenge that ties the income paths together.

Take them in the order your situation needs, not the order they are numbered. If you have no clients yet, finish this course's fourteen days first. A second course cannot fix an empty portfolio.

# The whole course on one page

If you remember nothing else, remember this order. It is the same order every time, from your first sample to your twentieth client.

**01** Choose three products and refuse to sell anything else yet.

**02** Two fonts, three colours, one margin, one alignment. Squint before you send.

**03** Ask the print shop six questions before you design anything for print.

**04** Build ten labelled pieces before you have a client.

**05** Price from your hours, adjust for the client, and write the number down.

**06** Two revision rounds included. One collected list per round. Said before you start.

**07** Twenty prospects a week, with the gap written next to each name.

**08** One small labelled sample, sent once, with one easy question.

**09** Half up front, half on approval, one shared folder, a written receipt.

**10** Deliver early, ask for the referral on delivery day, and offer the retainer.

That single rule has protected more beginner designers than any pricing strategy.

NexKit your country Editorial Team · Canva to Cash · First Edition · September 2026

GLOBAL EDITION · FIRST EDITION · SEPTEMBER 2026

# Canva to Cash

How to Start a Simple Graphic Design Service Using Free Tools

LEGAL, DISCLAIMER AND HOW TO READ THIS

## Copyright & Disclaimer

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This course was written and edited by the NexKit your country Editorial Team. It is not attributed to an individual author, and no personal credentials, photographs or biographies are presented anywhere in it. It is sold as a digital course for personal use by the buyer.

### What this course is

A practical, your country-specific manual for starting a small graphic design service using free tools and, where necessary, only a phone. It teaches the design rules that separate amateur work from professional work, the client work small local businesses actually buy, a ten-piece portfolio you can build before you have a single client, pricing in dollars, ten service packages, the exact words to send a client, how to find buyers, how to get paid legally where you live, and a fourteen-day plan that ends with real outreach sent.

Every price, fee and platform fact that is not clearly labelled as a teaching example is traceable to a published source listed in Sources & Further Reading.

### What this course is not

It is not a promise of income. It is not a guarantee of clients, replies, orders or results. It is not financial, legal, tax or investment advice, and it is not a substitute for a qualified accountant or lawyer where you live.

It does not claim that any particular design tool, free plan, template, export option or payment route is available to you today. Design is one of the most crowded beginner services where you live, and this course says so plainly instead of pretending otherwise.

DISCLAIMER — INCOME, EXAMPLES AND YOUR RESPONSIBILITIES

This course is educational only. **There is no income guarantee of any kind.** Nothing in it should be read as a prediction of what you will earn, how many clients will answer you, or how quickly you will be paid.

Every business, client, message and scenario in this course is invented for teaching, and every one is labelled **Example scenario — fictional**. Every price in dollars is an **example price for teaching**, not a market rate, not a published rate card and not a quotation. There is no published local rate card for design work that this course could verify, so you must calibrate your own prices by asking local businesses what they currently pay.

You are responsible for complying with local law, your tax obligations, the terms of service of any platform you use, and the requirements of any bank, wallet or payment provider you receive money through. Rules, fees, limits and country availability change. Verify anything that matters to you before you rely on it.

FIGURES, DATES AND UNRESOLVED QUESTIONS

All figures cited in this course are current as of **September 2026** unless a specific date is printed next to the figure. Source URLs for those figures appear in **Sources & Further Reading** at the back of this course.

local payment rules, data prices and platform availability move quickly. Where this course could not verify a fact, it says so in the text and tells you to confirm it yourself. Those gaps were left as gaps on purpose.

### ON DESIGN TOOLS, FONTS AND PRINT SHOPS

This course teaches rules and a workflow that work in any template-based free design tool. Tool names appear as examples only. Free-plan limits, template libraries, font lists and export options change without notice, and they were not verified against the vendor pages for this edition. **Check the current free limits yourself before you build a workflow on any tool.**

Printing prices, paper stock, bleed requirements and turnaround times are set by individual print shops. This course does not print a single printing price, because there is no verified public source for one. Ask your own print shop.

**Last updated:** September 2026. Questions or corrections: use the contact address supplied with your purchase.

# What is inside this course

01 · The Ten Things local Clients Actually Buy 10
02 · Design Fundamentals That Separate Amateur From Professional 14
03 · The Design Workflow in a Free Tool, From Phone and From Laptop 20
04 · Your Portfolio: Ten Pieces, No Clients 25
05 · Pricing and Ten Sample Service Packages 29
06 · Revisions, Feedback and Not Going Crazy 34
07 · Finding local Clients 39
08 · Outreach That Works for Design 46
09 · Client Management, Delivery and Getting Paid where you live 51
10 · A Fourteen-Day Portfolio Launch Plan 57

**HOW TO WORK THROUGH THIS COURSE**

Skim the section dividers first so you can see the whole route. Then work one section at a time and finish the **DO** tasks before moving to the next. The scripts, templates and checklists are meant to be copied, filled in and sent — not admired.